

MCD to decriminalise minor civic offences

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Sunday stated that the amendments aimed to decriminalise minor civic offences and make municipal laws more citizen-friendly.

The statement comes against the backdrop of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada in the Lok Sabha on Friday and proposes multiple amendments in the DMC Act.

The proposed changes seek to remove criminal penalties, including imprisonment, for minor violations and replace them with a more compliance-based framework. The move is intended to reduce harassment, cut litigation, and promote a more comfortable and business-friendly environment in the Capital.

According to the mayor's office, the amendments mark a shift from punitive enforcement to a balanced system that encourages cooperation



between citizens and civic authorities.

One of the central features of the proposal is the decriminalisation of minor and technical offences. Violations that earlier attracted criminal prosecution will now be treated as civil matters.

Officials said this will prevent unnecessary legal action and reduce the social stigma associated with minor civic lapses.

The amendments also propose the complete removal of imprisonment provisions for certain municipal violations. These include

offences related to employment-related defaults and other minor breaches. Authorities said such violations should not lead to criminal liability.

In addition, several outdated provisions under the existing Act are proposed to be scrapped. These include clauses that impose negligible fines or are no longer relevant in the current administrative context. Officials said such provisions will either be removed or addressed through administrative mechanisms.

The MCD has also focused

on simplifying licensing-related rules.

Provisions governing markets, trades, and eating establishments are proposed to be eased by replacing criminal penalties with reasonable monetary fines. This step is expected to improve the ease of doing business and reduce the compliance burden on small businesses.

Officials said the changes will also encourage more businesses to operate within the formal system.

"Simplified regulations and proportionate penalties will promote voluntary

compliance," an official statement said.

While the amendments aim to reduce punitive action, they also include provisions for stricter penalties in cases of repeated or serious violations. Authorities said this is necessary to ensure deterrence while maintaining fairness and proportionality.

The overarching objective of the reforms is to create a more transparent, efficient, and citizen-centric governance framework.

The MCD said the amendments will help reduce unnecessary legal proceedings and promote trust-based governance. "These changes are aimed at making municipal laws more humane, practical, and responsive to the needs of citizens," the statement said.

The reforms are also aligned with the broader governance vision of "minimum government, maximum governance". Officials said the focus is on ensuring effective regulation without excessive legal intervention. The civic body reiterated that public order, hygiene, and safety will remain priorities.

LG Sandhu visits Connaught Place, engages with public on civic issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu made an unannounced visit to Connaught Place on Sunday, interacting directly with citizens and gathering feedback on civic issues.

The visit, described as impromptu, is part of a series of informal public engagements by the LG aimed at understanding ground realities and promoting people-centric governance.

Sandhu began his visit at a popular outlet, Keventers, where he bought a milkshake and interacted with the people present there. While engaging with visitors, he informally assessed the condition of sanitation and traffic in the Connaught Place area.

Officials said the LG spoke to people from different parts of Delhi, including professionals and young residents, who shared their experiences related to commuting, cleanliness and



public infrastructure in the city.

From there, Sandhu walked to the well-known Jain Chawal Wale eatery. He stood in line like a regular customer, purchased a plate of kadhi chawal and ate among the crowd. The gesture drew attention from visitors and passersby, many of whom interacted with him during the visit.

During his interactions, the LG emphasised the importance of public participation in governance. He asked people to share solutions to civic problems and said that governance must be driven by the needs and inputs of citizens.

"Experience has taught me that governance has to be people-centric. Solutions to people's issues should come from the people themselves," he said during the visit.

He also underlined the need for a "bottom-up" approach, where policies and decisions are shaped by feedback from the ground, rather than being imposed from the top.

Officials noted that this was not the first such visit by the LG. Similar interactive outings have been conducted earlier in areas such as Model Town, Vasant Vihar, Chittaranjan Park and near the Red Fort.

Police bust gang posing as bank recovery agents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted a gang posing as bank recovery agents and extorting money from vehicle owners on city roads using mobile technology. Four accused have been arrested in connection with the racket, officials said on Sunday.

The gang used a mobile application to identify vehicles with pending EMIs and then targeted owners on busy roads. They allegedly threatened victims and forced them to transfer money online.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (East) Rajeev Kumar said the accused used a "systematic and technology-driven method" to identify and target victims. "They impersonated recovery agents, intimidated people, and extorted money through digital transactions. Further investigation is underway to



identify more victims and associates," he said.

The case came to light after a complaint by Keshav Kumar, who alleged that he was stopped near Vikas Marg, close to ITO, on March 26.

According to police, he was intercepted by men in a white car, forcibly taken aside, assaulted, and threatened.

The accused then forced him to transfer ₹18,000 online before letting him go. Based on the complaint, an FIR was registered at Shakarpur

police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Police said a special team was formed immediately after the case was registered. During the investigation, officers used technical surveillance and local intelligence to trace the suspects. A breakthrough came after inputs from a secret informer indicated that individuals from Baghpat in Uttar Pradesh were involved.

Police said further analysis of mobile data and location

tracking confirmed the suspects' presence at the crime scene. Based on this, multiple raids were conducted, leading to the arrest of four accused: Prince (22), Shivam (23), Teetu alias Tittu (22), all from Baghpat, and Aakash alias Akku (25) from Kharkhari Loni in Uttar Pradesh.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed to their involvement in the case and admitted to carrying out similar incidents. Police said none of them had prior criminal records.

Investigators also revealed the gang's modus operandi. The accused used a mobile app to identify vehicles with pending EMIs. They would then follow or intercept these vehicles using a white car without a number plate.

Posing as bank recovery agents, they would stop the vehicle owners, threaten them with consequences, and, in some cases, assault them.

Police dismantle drug racket, arrest 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Crime Branch has dismantled a major interstate drug network and seized psychotropic substances worth over ₹4.5 crore, officials said on Sunday. Four accused have been arrested in the operation led by the Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF).

Deputy Commissioner of Police (ANTF) Rahool Alwal said the action was part of a sustained crackdown on organised narcotics trade. "This was a well-organised network dealing in commercial quantities of psychotropic drugs. We have seized large consignments and arrested key operatives. Further investigation is underway," he said.

Police said a total of 3.539 kg of Alprazolam tablets, valued at around ₹3.5 crore in the international market, and 1.709 kg of Tramadol



tablets and capsules, worth about ₹1 crore, were recovered during the operation.

The case was registered under relevant sections of the NDPS Act at the Crime Branch police station on March 18. According to officials, the operation began on March 17 after specific intelligence inputs were received about a drug consignment being moved in northeast Delhi. Acting on the information, a police team laid a trap at Shiv Vihar Tiraha on

Johripur Road.

During the interception, one accused, Nitin Pathak (20), along with a child in conflict with the law, was caught while transporting narcotics on a motorcycle.

Police recovered 11,900 Alprazolam tablets weighing 1.912 kg and 825 Tramadol tablets weighing 0.491 kg from them. Further investigation led to a series of follow-up raids. Based on Pathak's interrogation, police raided a medical store in Bhopura,

Uttar Pradesh, owned by Prem Singh Yadav (30). From his shop, 2,250 Tramadol capsules weighing 1.218 kg were recovered. He was arrested on March 19.

Subsequently, on March 21, another accused, Shalu Kumar (45), was arrested after a raid at his residence. Police recovered 11,955 Alprazolam tablets weighing 1.627 kg from him.

In the next phase of the operation, Sanjay Singh (36) was arrested on March 23 following disclosures made by Shalu Kumar. Police said the accused were part of a structured supply chain dealing in illegal pharmaceutical drugs. Investigators found that each member had a specific role in procurement, storage, and distribution.

Nitin Pathak, a B.Sc. graduate and former medical representative, allegedly entered the illegal trade after learning about the high demand for such drugs.

Forged no-entry permit racket busted, one held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Traffic Police has busted a racket involved in the use of forged no-entry permissions by commercial vehicle operators in east Delhi, arresting one person and seizing a light goods vehicle, an official said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Saleem, 45, a resident of Sunder Nagri, was

apprehended by traffic staff of Nand Nagri Circle during a special enforcement drive, he said.

After the police received information regarding certain commercial vehicle drivers operating during restricted hours using fabricated no-entry permissions (NEPs), traffic personnel were deployed at key points to verify documents of commercial vehicles during

restricted hours, a senior police officer said. On March 27, at around 6 pm, a team intercepted a Tata Ace vehicle near Loni Golchakkar on Wazirabad Road.

The vehicle was moving towards Khajuri Khas during the restricted time window between 5 pm and 11 pm, when entry of such vehicles is prohibited, he said.

"During inspection, the driver displayed a purported

NEP pasted on the windscreen. However, verification through the official challan system revealed that no such permission had been issued for the vehicle, confirming that the document was forged," he added. The accused was detained and later handed over to the Gokulpuri police station along with the vehicle.

The police registered a case and initiated an investigation, police said.

During interrogation, Saleem disclosed that he had not applied for any legitimate no-entry permission. He allegedly procured the forged document through an acquaintance, Nazim, who introduced him to an unidentified person near the Burari Transport Authority.

Efforts are underway to identify and apprehend other persons involved in the racket, police said.

40 sex workers join session on self-esteem, mental well-being

SAUMYA SHUKLA ■ New Delhi

A small hall of a multi-storey brothel in Delhi's red-light area, Garstin Bastion Road, popularly known as GB Road, became an unlikely venue for a session on mental health and self-worth when about 40 sex workers paused their daily routines and gathered for the sitting. During the two-hour session, the hall echoed with affirmations such as "Main khud ke liye garv mehsoos karti hoon" (I feel proud of myself).

Handling between 15 and 20 customers a day and often under the influence of intoxicants, these moments provide them with a scarce respite and an opportunity to laugh.

In the hall, which has five small enclosures, each measuring 3 feet by 5 feet, used by the women to sleep and carry out their work, the sex workers — aged between 20 and 50 — were asked to write their names on sheets marked with different emojis to symbolise their moods.

"These women struggle to write their names. Most of them have little understanding of what constitutes a crime against them. Their internalised trauma has made them numb to physical pain," said an NGO worker



who counsels them regularly. The programme was led by Sub-Inspector Kiran, popularly known as 'Lady Singham', who heads the All-Women Police Post (Mahila Police Chowki) at GB Road, in collaboration with an NGO.

The Mahila Police Chowki has, since its inception in February 2024 as one of the first two all-women police posts in the city, emerged as a quiet yet powerful space for empowerment in an area that houses hundreds of multi-storey brothels and over 1,000 sex workers.

The police post has been running regular skill development and awareness programmes aimed at helping women from economically weaker sections move towards self-reliance.

Coaching classes, makeup artist training, sewing courses, cooking sessions, aerobics, and counselling are among the initiatives conducted on the first floor of the

police post. Other activities include embroidery, bag-making, pot-making, and creative exposure through film-related initiatives.

Self-defence and awareness sessions are also held regularly. On March 22, around 50 women participated in a police-led programme where they were sensitised about their rights.

Educational activities are conducted for children in the area as well, benefiting over 50 girls with basic education and introductory computer knowledge.

Health and hygiene form a key component of the initiative. Regular health camps have been organised since 2023, benefiting both sex workers and residents. Nearly 500 individuals have been provided with spectacles, while dental check-ups are conducted with support from Maulana Azad Dental Hospital. Awareness on hygiene, including the distribution of sanitary napkins and guidance on safe practices, is also carried out.

Mental health counselling is offered for nearly 20 days a month at a dedicated counselling room within the police chowki. De-addiction awareness campaigns and psychological assessments are also part of the outreach. (PTI)

Shooter held, weapon recovered

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Special Cell of Delhi Police has arrested a key shooter linked to the Rohit Godara-Goldy Brar-Virender Charan gang and recovered a loaded semi-automatic pistol from his hideout in Sainik Vihar, officials said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Deepak Kumar alias Dilawar (26), a resident of Unnao district in Uttar Pradesh, was allegedly involved in a firing incident in Punjab and was operating on instructions from gang handlers. "This arrest is part of our sustained crackdown on organised crime networks operating across multiple states," said DCP Praveen



Kumar Tripathi of the Special Cell. "The accused was actively involved in violent activities linked to extortion cases and was trying to establish a base in Delhi."

Police said the gang has been involved in multiple extortion cases across Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Punjab. In one such case in December 2025, gangster Virender Charan allegedly demanded ₹10 crore from a

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the public at large that my clients Ashutosh Pathak and his wife Anshul Pathak both R/o 6/671, Lodhi Colony, South Delhi, Delhi-110003 have disowned and debar their daughter Akshita Pathak aged 24 years from their all moveable & immovable properties with immediate effect and severed all relations with her because she is out of control of my clients, misbehaves with them. Anybody dealing with her in any manner whatsoever will be doing at his/ her own risk, consequences and responsibilities there to and my clients shall be in no way liable for any act, deeds and things done by her in any manner whatsoever.

Kaushal Tiwari (Advocate)
Ch. No. 684 Saket Court New Delhi-17

One injured in mini truck, car collision in Pitampura

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 21-year-old man was seriously injured on Sunday after his car collided with a mini truck that was allegedly driven recklessly on the wrong side of the road in northwest Delhi's Pitampura, police said.

The accident occurred

around 5.30 am near RP Chowk when the car, coming from the Netaji Subhash Place side, rammed into the mini truck that had entered the carriageway from the wrong direction, they added.

"The impact badly damaged the car and injured one of the occupants," a senior police officer said.

The injured Parth Gambir,



a resident of Pitampura, was rushed to a private hospital, where he was admitted for treatment, he said, the officer said.

Another man, Raghu Mathur, sustained minor injuries and was taken to Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital for medical examination, where he was stated to be stable, the officer said.



Baba Farid University of Health Sciences
Sadiq Road, Faridkot -151203 Ph. 01639-256232, 256236

E-TENDER NOTICE

Online bids are invited through the e-tendering process for procurement of the following services/items through the E-Procurement portal of the Government of Punjab.

Last date for submission of online bids of following tender's is 17-04-2026

1) Rate Contract for Supply of Printers and Multifunctional Printers (MFPs) 2) Supply and Installation of Physiotherapy Equipment for Goindwal Sahib. 3) Rate contract for Supply, installation, testing and commissioning of Desktop computers all-in-one computer, Laptop and UPS. 4) Rate Contract for Supply of Print Books E-Books.

Last date for submission of online bids of following tender's is 29-04-2026

1) Procure of sound system, Display 75" and 43" for setup of Model Classrooms. 2) Procure of Skill Equipment as per skill Norms for Two skill Labs at HSDC, Patiala. 3) Rate Contract for hiring one services of Tent & event infrastructure for various events. 4) Providing Outsourced Manpower Services for The Class IV Staff, Mails and Drivers. 5) Providing outsourced manpower services for technical staff such as Computer Operators, Data Entry Operators, Technicians, Mechanics etc, and Nursing Staff as Nursing Supdt., Nursing sisters, Staff Nurses and ANM etc

Note:- Tender Document can be downloaded from <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in> and www.bfuhis.ac.in

REGISTRAR

3108/12/2025-26/9947 Dated CHD :- 27/03/2026



REGD. OFFICE: ESAF Bhavan, Mannuthy, Thrissur- 680 651, Kerala

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts and remaining overdue/ unredeemed despite repeated notices will be auctioned for recovery of the Bank's dues, in accordance with applicable banking regulations and policies.

DETAILS OF AUCTION

Mode of Auction: Off-line (Physical Auction through Branches)

Date of Auction: 28-04-2026 **Time:** 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM

Auction Venues: The auction will be conducted at the following ESAF Small Finance Bank branches in Haryana

Interested bidders are requested to visit the respective branches for participation. For detailed branch addresses and contact numbers, please visit the Bank's official website

BRANCH NAME - LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER

Faridabad: 75250000540045

Important Instructions: Borrowers may redeem their pledged gold ornaments by clearing the total dues along with applicable charges at least two days prior to the auction date. Interested bidders must carry valid KYC documents. GST Registration Number is mandatory for firms/companies, wherever applicable. Bidders are required to deposit an Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Rs.2,500 before participating in the auction. The auction will be conducted on an "as is where is" and "as is what is" basis. The Bank reserves the right to cancel/postpone the auction or reject any bid without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBJA Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.

Place: Thrissur (Sd/-) Authorized Signatory
Date: 30-03-2026 ESAF Small Finance Bank

Mysuru man held for sending bomb threats to courts, schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested a 47-year-old man from Mysuru in Karnataka for allegedly sending a series of hoax bomb threat emails to courts and schools in the national capital, officials said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Shrinivas Luis, was apprehended from his residence in Vrindavan Layout during a raid conducted by a Delhi Police team on Saturday. Police have seized his mobile phones, laptop, and other electronic devices.

Officials said Luis is highly educated and holds a post-graduate degree but is currently unemployed. He lives with his mother, a retired government school teacher. According to police sources, Luis is also a law school dropout who could not complete his final year. Investigators suspect that



frustration related to his academic background may have been one of the reasons behind targeting the courts. "It is suspected that he wanted to stall court proceedings. He has sent several emails to the Delhi High Court and district courts over the past few months," a police source said.

Preliminary investigation suggests that the accused sent over 1,000 emails to various institutions across the country. A majority of

these were directed at courts, including the Delhi High Court and several district courts in the capital.

Police are also verifying whether he sent similar threat emails to schools in Delhi. Over the past two years, the city has witnessed more than 50 such incidents, targeting over 500 schools and government institutions. Officials believe the arrest could help crack multiple pending cases involving hoax threats. Investigators suspect that Luis

used a virtual private network (VPN) to conceal his identity while sending the emails.

A VPN allows users to mask their location and identity by routing internet activity through encrypted servers, making it difficult to trace the source. The accused is being brought to Delhi after being produced before a local court in Karnataka. Police said they will seek his custody for detailed interrogation. "We need to ascertain the exact number of emails sent and the full extent of his activities, including the motive behind targeting specific institutions," an officer said.

One of the earlier incidents under investigation dates back to September, when the Delhi High Court received a bomb threat email claiming that three explosive devices had been planted on the premises. The threat was later declared a hoax after thorough checks.

Four injured as they jump from first floor of building after it catches fire in Gokal Puri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Four people, including a child, were injured after they jumped from the first floor of a residential building in northeast Delhi's Gokal Puri area to escape a fire that broke out in the early hours of Sunday.

The incident was reported around 2.30 am from a house in F block in the Chand Bagh area near Bhajanpura when the building was engulfed in heavy smoke after two scooters and a motorcycle parked on the ground floor caught fire, the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said.

Eight other residents, including children, who were trapped on the second, third and fourth floors, also managed to save their lives when the firefighters reached the spot and rescued them.

An official said that by the time the firefighters reached the spot, four people, three



women along with a child, had already jumped.

"They were identified as Nikhat (22), Rashida (50), Soni (25) and Ashif (2). All four were taken to Jag Pravesh Chand Hospital and discharged after first aid," said Anoop Singh, station officer at Geeta Colony Fire Station.

Eyewitnesses said they woke up to loud cries for help and a burning smell in the night as panic spread through the building.

"I woke up to loud cries and a burning smell around

2:30 am. When I stepped out, flames were coming from the parking area, and thick smoke was rising fast. We tried to alert everyone and help them come out," a local said.

He further said that children were crying and people were trying to find a way out as the staircase was completely choked with smoke.

Another local said that people were shouting to the residents to jump from the first floor.

"They were crying and

screaming for help. Locals helped them to rush them to nearby hospitals for treatment," she said.

Eyewitnesses added that residents on the upper floors were struggling to breathe due to the smoke and were trying to reach the terrace.

They described visuals of thick smoke billowing out of the multi-storey building in the narrow lane as firefighters carried out rescue operations, adding that residents, including women and children, had gathered on the street in panic, many coughing and covering their faces.

The ground-floor parking area appeared charred, while the walls of the upper floors were completely blackened, residents said.

"The smoke was so thick we couldn't see anything beyond a few feet. People were coughing, covering their faces and trying to find a way out in the dark," said a resident.

Traffic eases on Vikas Marg after crackdown, new measures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Traffic flow on East Delhi's busy Vikas Marg corridor has improved significantly following a series of enforcement and traffic management measures by the Delhi Traffic Police on Sunday.

According to the Traffic Police, average travel time on the stretch has reduced from 20-25 minutes to around 14-15 minutes after sustained action against violations and infrastructure changes.

Vikas Marg is one of the most important arterial roads connecting the Trans-Yamuna areas to Central Delhi. The corridor witnesses heavy traffic due to dense commercial activity, residential colonies, and high pedestrian move-

ment. It is also supported by major metro stations such as Laxmi Nagar, Preet Vihar, and Nirman Vihar.

Officials said the stretch had been facing long-standing issues, including illegal roadside parking, broken central dividers, and congestion caused by multiple feeder lanes merging into the main road. To address these problems, Delhi Traffic Police launched targeted enforcement drives along with structural and regulatory changes.

"Strict enforcement, better coordination with civic agencies, and improved traffic management have led to smoother movement and better road discipline on Vikas Marg," said Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Vijayanta Goyal Arya.



Over the past two weeks, enforcement teams towed away 198 vehicles parked illegally. Nearly 200 vehicles were also clamped for improper parking, reducing bottlenecks along the corridor. Officials said a total of 11,005 challans have been issued so far in 2026 for violations such as illegal

parking and unauthorized e-rickshaw operations. Special drives are also underway to remove encroachments from footpaths.

In addition to enforcement, several traffic management steps have been introduced. Adequate traffic personnel have been deployed at key junctions to

regulate movement and prevent congestion. Dedicated cranes have been stationed along the stretch to ensure the quick removal of obstructing vehicles.

Signal systems have also been modified to improve flow. The Laxmi Nagar intersection has been made signal-free, reducing stoppage time for commuters. Meanwhile, the Karkari Mor junction is being redesigned with infrastructure upgrades, including plans for flyovers and underpasses to enable smoother movement.

Authorities have also taken steps to streamline road access. Entry to the Master Plan Road from Karkari Mor has been restricted to prevent wrong-side driving and reduce conflict points.

Subsidy bill rises on power, free bus travel in 2025-26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The subsidy bill of the Delhi Government towards the free bus travel scheme for women and electricity has enhanced substantially even as funds for its ambitious IT projects have faced cuts, according to revised budget estimates for the current year.

The modified Revised Estimates (RE) figures released recently by the finance department showed that the outlay for the power subsidy has been increased to around ₹4,200 crore, compared to the Budget Estimate (BE) of ₹3,849 crore for the

year. The revision reflects additional requirements to clear pending dues and meet higher demand under the electricity subsidy scheme due to growing consumer numbers.

The Delhi Government provides free electricity up to 200 units of monthly consumption, and those using 201 to 400 units are paid a 50 per cent subsidy.

The RE for the transport department showed that the subsidy to DTC for female commuters (eligible for free travel in public transport buses) has gone up to ₹328 crore against the budget estimate (BE) of ₹240 crore.

The subsidy for cluster ser-

vices for free travel is also revised to ₹342 crore from the BE of ₹200 crore in 2026-27.

The total amount of subsidy to female commuters has increased to ₹670 crore against the BE of ₹440 crore, documents showed.

According to budget (RE) documents, the Information Technology department had an outlay of ₹690.5 crore for the 2025-26 financial year, but revised estimates peg actual spending at just ₹215 crore, a steep shortfall of nearly 69 per cent. Officials said the RE estimates show cuts in various IT initiatives, including the Unified Data Hub project, which was allocated ₹250 crore.

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IN FOCUS



People en route to Kolhapur for Jyotiba Yatra, a three-day festival held annually in April at the Jyotiba Temple, travel in bullock carts on the Pune-Bangalore Highway-48 in Karad, Satara district, Maharashtra

PTI

Threat to Constitution remains till BJP in power: Akhilesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Noida

Those who talked about winning 400 seats to change the Constitution have been defeated but the danger will remain till the BJP is in power, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav said on Sunday, launching a scathing attack on the ruling party as he kicked off the campaign for the 2027 Uttar Pradesh election.

Addressing a rally in Dadri, Yadav countered Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remarks a day earlier at the inauguration of the Noida International Airport and alleged that several airports inaugurated by the BJP were not operational.

"Earlier also airports were inaugurated by them, but out of seven, six are not functional," he claimed and said the Government should have



given an assurance that the airport would "not be sold later". He also promised fair compensation to farmers for land acquisition once his party comes to power.

The remarks came a day after Prime Minister Modi, while inaugurating the airport in Jewar, targeted the Samajwadi Party (SP), alleging that it had turned Noida into an "ATM for loot" during its tenure. He had also taken a dig at opposition leaders for allegedly avoiding Gautam Buddh Nagar due to "superstitions".

Stay united, avoid rumors: PM says...

The Prime Minister said West Asia is a major centre of India's energy needs and on account of that, a crisis is emerging around the world regarding petrol and diesel.

"Our global relations, the support we receive from various countries and the strengths the country has built over the past decade have enabled India to bravely confront these circumstances," he said. At the outset of this address, Modi said the month of March has been full of turbulence globally. He said all citizens of the country remember that the entire world faced myriad problems for a long time on account of Covid. "Indeed, all of us had expected that after emerging from the Corona crisis, the world would move forward on the path of renewed progress," Modi said. However, he said, situations of war and conflict have continuously arisen in different parts of the world.

The West Asia conflict started on February 28. While the US and Israel attacked Iran, the Islamic Republic retaliated by targeting Washington's allies in its neighbourhood and Tel Aviv. Iran controls the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which 20 per cent of the world's energy is transported. Since the conflict began, Iran has allowed very few ships to cross it. Modi has spoken to a number of world leaders, including those from Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, Iran, France, Israel and Malaysia, since the conflict started.

He has also spoken to US President Donald Trump. After a telephonic conversation between the two on March 24, Modi said he "had a useful exchange of views on the situation in West Asia".

LS to discuss anti-Naxal drive as Amit Shah's...

This has evolved into intelligence-led operations, inter-state coordination, and efforts to choke Maoist financing, along with infrastructure expansion in affected areas.

According to government data, between 2004 and March 26, 2026, a total of 16,496 Naxals have surrendered. The year 2025 alone saw the highest number of surrenders at 2,337.

The number of affected districts has steadily declined from 126 in 2014 to 90 (2018), 70 (2021), 38 (April 2024), 18 (April 2025), 11 (late 2025), and further to 7-8 by early 2026. Currently affected districts include Bijapur, Narayanpur, Sukma, Kanker and Dantewada in Chhattisgarh; West Singhbhum in Jharkhand; and Kandhamal in Odisha. Of these, only three are categorised as "most affected." Violent incidents have dropped sharply-by 81-88% from the 2010 peak of 1,936 to 374 in 2024 and around 234 in 2025. Police stations reporting LWE violence declined from 465 in 2010 to 119 in 2025.

Civilian and security force fatalities have also fallen by 85-91%, from 1,005 in 2010 to about 150 in 2024 and roughly 95-100 in 2025. Between 2014 and 2024, security force casualties declined by 73% compared to the previous decade.

In 2025 alone, 317 Naxals were neutralised, including top leadership; over 800 were arrested, and nearly 2,000 surrendered-marking a turning point in the government's "Naxal Muk

Govt ramps up measures to ensure fuel, LPG supplies

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The Government has stepped up measures to secure fuel and gas supplies amid the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, while urging citizens to avoid panic buying as sporadic rushes were reported at fuel stations.

In a statement, giving an update on developments following the war in West Asia, the oil ministry said refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, and stocks of petrol and diesel remain sufficient nationwide. Retail outlets are functioning normally, even as rumours triggered temporary spikes in demand in some states.

"There were certain rumours, which led to panic buying at some retail outlets in a few states, resulting in

unusually high sales and heavy crowding at retail outlets. However, it is informed that there are adequate stocks of petrol and diesel available at all petrol pumps in the country," it said.

To boost domestic availability, the Government has cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre and imposed export levies of ₹21.50 per litre on diesel and ₹29.50 per litre on aviation turbine fuel (ATF).

In the gas sector, supplies have been prioritised for households and transport, with 100 per cent allocation to piped natural gas (PNG) and CNG, while industrial and commercial users are receiving about 80 per cent of average consumption. Fertiliser plants are being supplied at 70-75 per cent, with additional LNG cargoes



A man carrying an LPG cylinder amid disruptions in LPG supplies due to the ongoing West Asia war, in Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra

being sourced, it said.

The ministry said the expansion of city gas distribution networks is being accelerated by streamlining approvals and pushing a shift from LPG to piped natural gas (PNG). Daily refill deliveries exceeded 55 lakh

cylinders, and measures to curb diversion have been tightened, it said.

Commercial LPG supply has been gradually restored to about 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, with priority given to hospitality, food services and key industries.

India-US: Gor outlines 'win-win' economic growth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

India's growing economy and massive infrastructure needs align perfectly with American expertise in energy, advanced manufacturing and digital infrastructure and both sides are well-positioned for a 'win-win' expansion of their strategic economic pillar, US Ambassador Sergio Gor has said.

The envoy said the two countries are prioritising building resilient supply chains for semiconductors and critical minerals, and welcomed New Delhi joining the US-led 'Pax Silica' initiative, which aims to secure these networks amid intense competition from China. In an interview to Span magazine, a US embassy publication, the ambassador said Washington is uniquely positioned to serve as the "main facilitator" of economic growth across South and



Central Asia and that its proposed trade deal with India will create a "powerful anchor" for regional economic integration.

Elaborating on the US' defence and security cooperation with India, he said it represents the "most strategically significant" area of collaboration between the two sides and mentioned cooperation under the framework of Quad.

"My vision is to transform the US-India relationship

tion and transnational crime as security and economic prosperity are "intertwined".

"India is a major defence partner, and defence cooperation is one of the brightest spots in our bilateral relationship. We also strengthen US-India military interoperability through participation in military exercises such as Malabar, Tiger Triumph and Cope India," he said.

"Both of our nations are also part of the Quad, a strategic partnership that keeps our security interests robust and aligned. These three core aspects — diplomacy, defence exercises and military sales — ensure strong, continued defence cooperation". Gor, known to be a key member of US President Donald Trump's inner circle, extensively highlighted the various aspects of US-India economic ties, adding that investment and trade expansion offer transformative potential.

FROM PAGE - 1

BJP," he said. Modi said both fronts are targeting the BJP out of fear. "This means that if these two corrupt parties are afraid of anyone, it is the BJP. They fear the BJP because they believe that if the BJP comes to power, all their wrongdoings will be exposed," he said.

He alleged that successive LDF and UDF governments have been involved in major scams and failed to act against each other. Modi also claimed that the Congress and the Left are allies in several states across the country but present themselves as rivals in Kerala. "Look at Bihar, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh, Manipur, Tripura, Assam and Tamil Nadu — the Congress and the Communists are together. But here in Kerala, they abuse each other. People must remain cautious of both," he said.

Attacking the Left government, which has ruled the state for the past 10 years, Modi said Kerala's public debt has crossed ₹5 lakh crore and has increased more than threefold in the last decade. Highlighting central assistance, Modi said Kerala has received significantly higher funds under the NDA government at the Centre compared with previous Congress-led regimes.

Reaching out to the people of Palakkad, where the party has fielded its firebrand leader Shobha Surendran, Modi highlighted the significance of the Kalpathy Temple, often compared with Kashi. "As a Member of Parliament from Kashi, this makes it even more special for me," he said. He emphasised the NDA's focus on women-led development and cited initiatives aimed at financial inclusion, healthcare and housing. "To ensure greater participation of women in legislatures, we have passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Act," he said.

Modi also referred to sexual assault allegations against the sitting MLA of Palakkad, Rahul Mamkootathil, who won the bypoll held in 2024 on a Congress ticket, and a recent similar case involving a Congress councillor.

Recalling the previous Assembly election, he noted that the BJP had fielded 'Metro Man' E Sreedharan in Palakkad, where he finished second. "We were saddened by that result, and so were the people of Palakkad," he said. He said the BJP has fielded Shobha Surendran this time and urged voters to ensure her victory.

Rail hospital scam: CBI names officials, kin

These bills, including inflated or deficient ones, were processed and passed by Chawla and a junior clerk, Hasan Yadav, before being forwarded to the Medical Accounts Section at Baroda House. At Baroda House, Senior Section Officer Hirakant Choudhary and Junior Accounts Assistant Raghuvendra Singh allegedly issued payment orders in exchange for bribes. Hospital representatives are paid at each stage to get bills cleared quickly. Venkateshwar Hospital in Dwarka, whose representatives Manish Aggarwal and Kunal are named in the FIR, is the specific private hospital at the centre of the investigation. The FIR documents a detailed money trail. On January 7 and 8, 2026, Chawla informed Aggarwal that hospital bills worth approximately ₹75 lakh were being processed. He subsequently demanded more money, telling Aggarwal on January 10 and again on January 13

TWO MORE INDIAN LPG TANKERS CARRYING DAY'S COOKING GAS CROSS STRAIT OF HORMUZ

New Delhi: Two more Indian-flagged LPG tankers, carrying roughly a day's supply of the country's cooking gas, have safely navigated through the war-hit Strait of Hormuz and are expected to reach Indian shores in the next couple of days. "Two LPG carriers, BW TYR and BW ELM, carrying a combined LPG cargo of about 94,000 tonnes, have safely transited the region and are moving towards Indian shores," an official statement said. While BW TYR is proceeding towards Mumbai with an expected arrival on March 31, BW ELM is en route to New Mangalore with an estimated arrival date of April 1. The US and Israel attacks on Iran and Tehran's sweeping

retaliation have all but halted shipping through the strait - the narrow shipping lane that is a conduit for oil and gas exports from Gulf countries to the world. Iran, however, last week said "non-hostile vessels" may transit the waterway after coordinating with Iranian authorities.

Previously, four Indian-flagged LPG tankers had safely sailed through the strait. Pine Gas and Jag Vasant, carrying 92,612 tonnes of LPG, reached Indian ports between March 26 and March 28. Prior to that, MT Shivalik and MT Nanda Devi, carrying about 92,712 tonnes of LPG, had reached Mundra port in Gujarat on March 16 and Kandla port in the state on March 17, respectively.

NGT notice to Uttarakhand over inaction in Mussoorie

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has issued a notice to Uttarakhand's chief secretary for not taking any "substantial action" regarding its directions to ensure that the environment of the "fragile" or ecologically sensitive region of Mussoorie is not disturbed.

The green body, in May last year, issued the order after disposing of a matter where it initiated suo motu (on its own) proceedings in view of a media report that the 2023 Joshimath disaster was a warning for Mussoorie, where unplanned constructions continued. "We dispose of this matter with a direction that the state of Uttarakhand will implement the 19 action points along with all other remedial measures based on sound scientific principles and practices to ensure that



the environment of the fragile Himalayan region is not disturbed beyond the carrying capacity," the tribunal's order had said.

The tribunal had sought an action taken report after six months. The NGT on March 24 this year noted that a report had been filed by the state's additional secretary in compliance with the tribunal's directions. A bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert members A Senthil Vel and Afroz Ahmad said, "On the perusal of the report, we find that no substantial action has been taken in respect of the relevant issues which were reflected in the order of the tribunal.

other cybercrimes anonymously and at lower costs, the officials said.

The operation came to light as part of the CBI's broader efforts to dismantle networks supporting cyber fraud, including misuse of telecom infrastructure. Following technical analysis of call data and patterns linked to fraud complaints, the agency conducted searches at six locations across Meerut and Noida in Uttar Pradesh. These raids targeted premises connected to the company and its directors, leading to the arrests on March 27, 2026. A CBI spokesperson stated.

The accused had allegedly incorporated the company solely to procure bulk SIM cards and facilitate SIM Box operations for cyber frauds. Following extensive technical analysis and coordinated field operations, two key accused were apprehended from Meerut. They were directors of the company.

SIM Box fraud has become a major enabler for cybercriminals in India, as it bypasses international call routing charges and helps mask the true source of spoofed calls used in scams. Authorities have intensified action against such setups under initiatives like Operation Chakra, targeting mule accounts, unauthorized SIM procurement and telecom misuse.

The arrested directors are currently in CBI custody, and further interrogations are expected to uncover the full extent of the network, including potential links to larger fraud syndicates and beneficiaries of the SIM Box operations.

In another operation, Meerut Police unmasked a tech savvy gang that was operating an illegal VoIP (Voice over internet protocol) exchange. It was a pretty sophisticated but illegal bypass that turned expensive international calls into cheap-looking local ones, primarily to hide identities and dodge government revenue. The illegal VoIP exchange being run from Lisadi Gate area was detected by the Department of Telecommunications (DoT).

Accordingly, sleuths from Special Weapons and Tactics (SWAT) and Anti-Terrorism Squad of the Meerut Police raided the premises which led to the arrest of six accused persons.

A case has been registered at the Lisadi Gate police station, and further investigation and legal action is underway, said a police official. Police are investigating the role of other players who could be based in other countries and were using VoIP calls to sidestep Indian intelligence agencies for launching subversive activities inside India. Investigation by the Meerut Police has found that the accused were running an unauthorized setup that converted international VoIP calls into local voice calls. VoIP routes voice calls over the internet (instead of traditional telecom networks), making them much cheaper.

The CBI has urged citizens to report suspicious calls or fraud attempts through official channels, such as the cybercrime portal (cybercrime.gov.in) or helpline 1930, and to remain vigilant against unsolicited calls demanding money or personal information. The two cases highlight the ongoing challenges in regulating bulk SIM issuance and telecom resources amid rising cyber threats in the country. Investigations are ongoing, with possible additional arrests anticipated.

GRAPEVINE

Madam's intimacy to Akbar Road office

Recently Government sent an eviction notice to Congress to vacate decades old office at Akbar Road. Many wonder why Congress keeping old small office, even after making a big Indira Bhavan at Deen Dayal Upadhyay Marg. Top Congress leaders say, old office, is adjacent to Sonia Gandhi's home 10 Janpath. She loves this old office and used party headquarters for evening walks. More than that 100s of people living in the old office compound are the workers of Madam's bungalow. Congress is wondering whether BJP Government is now planning to issue eviction notice to Nehru Bhawan on Raisina Road allotted to build Congress office, but later converted as Rajiv Gandhi Foundation's office.



Either spokesperson or not!

During a recent gathering at the residences of prominent Parliamentarians, journalists always craving for scoops and information learned something bizarre about a former Congress leader, who later entered Rajya Sabha from a different party. This leader described failure to convince Rahul Gandhi to appoint them as an AICC Secretary. According to the leader, Rahul Gandhi argued that being a spokesperson made holding other posts, like AICC Secretary, unnecessary. The leader then commented on the ambitions of Congress's most vocal spokespersons, who hope for Rajya Sabha berths with every biennial election around.



All is quiet at PHQ

In Delhi Police circles, new LGs (especially non-police background ones) often spark quiet speculation during the initial "Courtesy Call" phase. The Police Commissioner's early meeting with LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu was purely a briefing on law and order. There is a buzz that the new LG may order changes at the top in the Delhi Police to stamp his arrival. But everything is quiet on the reshuffle front right now. The big move already happened under the former LG VK Saxena and the new LG appears focused on the bigger picture and that's governance rather than immediate police brass changes. A career diplomat, Sandhu has been focusing on development, law & order, and stakeholder meetings (including a quick review with Police Commissioner Satish Golcha on security, cybercrime, shortly after taking charge).



Virendra Kumar calls to expand Nasha Mukht Bharat Abhiyan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Social Justice and Empowerment Virendra Kumar on Sunday called for intensifying preventive efforts, scaling up de-addiction services and expanding the Nasha Mukht Bharat Abhiyan, according to a statement.

Kumar chaired the fifth meeting of the National Consultative Committee on De-addiction and Rehabilitation (NCCDR) held at the Dr Ambedkar International Centre here. It was attended by Minister



of State BL Verma, Social Justice Secretary Sudhansh Pant, senior officials, representatives from States and Union Territories, NGOs and other stakeholders.

Addressing the gathering, Virendra Kumar urged all members to actively and regularly share their views, suggestions, and feedback on this critical national issue of drug demand reduction.

Aviation sector facing bottleneck in procurement of new aircraft: Naidu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhavnagar

Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu on Sunday said India's aviation sector is facing a bottleneck in procurement of new aircraft, citing that while 1,700 new planes are on order, supply chain disruptions mean deliveries may take up to 15 years.

Naidu, who flagged off new flights at Bhavnagar airport in Gujarat, stated that the Government is emphasising domestic manufacturing of aircraft through joint ventures with global giants like Embraer, and a partnership with Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) is already underway to produce the Sukhoi Superjet 100.

The minister remarked that building airports is not difficult once land is made available, but getting aircraft has become a major bottleneck after the COVID-19 pandemic. He explained that aircraft manufacturing has slowed down worldwide, affecting the speed at which planes are being delivered. "After COVID-19, there were many difficulties in aircraft manufacturing. There was some disruption in the supply chain. So the speed and scale at which aircraft were supposed to be



built have decreased," he said. He noted that 1,700 orders for aircraft are pending, and it will take up to 15 years for them to arrive. Naidu said Indian airline operators have placed large orders to meet rising demand, and around 30,000 pilots will be needed in the coming years to operate these aircraft. "When these aircraft start arriving, it will become easier for the airlines to fulfil the new aspirations and demands for connectivity," he said.

To deal with the shortage, the Government is working on speeding up aircraft imports and boosting domestic manufacturing under the 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat' and 'Make in India' initiatives, he said. The minister said the Government has been encouraging global companies to manu-

West Asia crisis: India on guard amid growing cyber threat

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

As the war between the US-Israel and Iran entered the fifth week on Saturday, with both the contesting parties sustaining significant attrition of weapons stockpile, and the international terror group Al Qaeda jumping into the West Asian conflict by declaring "global cyber jihad" against countries including India, the possibility of cyber hits against Indian installations has heightened.

Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), spearheading the war front with the US-Israel, has a precedent of downing a passenger aircraft of Ukraine International Airlines Flight 752 "mistakenly" on January 8, 2020, killing all 176 people on board. The incident occurred soon after Iran launched missile strikes against US forces in Iraq in retaliation for the assassination of IRGC General Qasem Soleimani by the American forces.

In the wake of heightened threat, India has so far issued broader advisories to the



airlines to operate only in open airspace and not for any specific precautions against on-ground or in-air flight operations by Indian airlines. Amid the West Asian conflict, at least one Indian international flight had to return following a software malfunction. Chatter emerging from Iran, all entities with linkages to the US and Israel's defence supply chains are "legitimate" targets for cyber hits.

Intelligence assessments suggest Iranian hacking groups could not only conduct cyber hits against Indian installations with US defence supply chain link-

ages, but even American and Pakistani hackers can target India in the disguise of Iranian hackers.

According to military theory on war escalation, cyber-attacks increase in geopolitical situations undergoing sustained conflict. Analysts monitoring the conflict said the Indian Airlines owned by the Tatas, part of the US defence supply chain, could be a possible target of Iranian hacking groups, causing flight disruption. Hackers' groups are already on the offensive to sway flight operations. The Tata group is engaged in the production of certain critical equipment for the American fighter jet F-16, including cockpit and ejection suites.

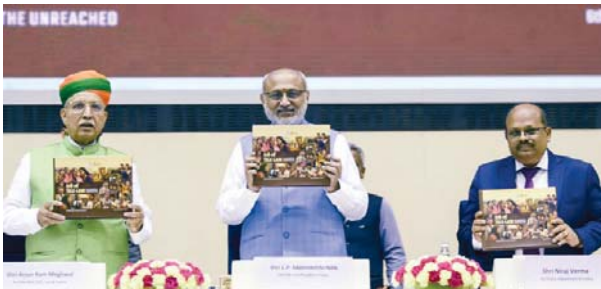
Al Qaeda, in a statement, said, "We call upon the believing men and women to join our ranks and participate in global Cyber Jihad against the American, Israeli, Pakistani, Indian and Arab Governments and to inflict financial loss and cyber disruptions against their Governments, financial institutions, Government businesses and agencies worldwide."

It added: "We announce our entrance into the Iranian-American war and the Afghanistan-Pakistan war. We will give cyber assistance to the Mujahideen of the Pakistani Taliban and the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan and launch major-scale cyber offensives against their enemies. We will also take the opportunity of the Iranian — American war by joining Pro-Iranian hacker movements and groups in their fight against the United States and Israel..."

Al Qaeda's affiliate, Harkat-ul Mujahideen and Jaish-e-Mohammad, have a track record of hijacking the Indian Airlines flight IC 813 from Kathmandu with 190 occupants in 1999, including one casualty. Indian Airlines was then operated by the Centre.

While there is no specific advisory against cyber threats, information in the open domain revealed that Indian Airlines flights are available to three destinations in the UAE, and the capitals of Oman and Qatar are already facing the brunt of the US-Israel-Iran conflict.

Justice not a privilege for few: Vice President



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal and others during the National Consultation on Tele-Law initiative

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday underscored the need for accessible, affordable and timely justice for all citizens and asserted that it is a right for all and not a privilege for a select few. He also called for inclusive, technology-driven access to justice under the law ministry's Tele-Law initiative.

Addressing a national consultation on the initiative here, Radhakrishnan highlighted recent legal reforms and said the transition to new criminal laws marks a historic shift towards a more citizen-centric justice system by simplifying procedures and improving efficiency.

He underlined the transformative role of technology in

governance, citing initiatives such as Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) and telemedicine, and described the Tele-Law initiative as a powerful tool to democratise legal services. He noted that pre-litigation legal advice can help resolve disputes early, reduce unnecessary litigation and ease the burden on courts.

Stressing the importance of linguistic inclusion, the vice president highlighted efforts to make the Constitution available in multiple regional languages and called for legal consultations to be provided in local languages to enhance understanding and participation. He also called for focused efforts to ensure last-mile delivery of legal services, particularly for women, rural and marginalised communities.

ATTENTION! GST TAXPAYERS

Whose Aggregate Annual Turnover[#] is upto a specified limit* can opt for GST Composition Scheme for the FY 2026–2027 by 31st March, 2026

Eligible taxpayers who wish to avail the Composition Scheme can follow these steps on the GST portal (www.gst.gov.in):

Log in to the Taxpayers' Interface

Go to Services >Registration > Application to Opt for Composition Levy

Fill the FORM GST CMP-02 and submit

Those eligible taxpayers, who are already availing Composition Scheme, need not file FORM CMP-02 if they are eligible.

Easy & Convenient Compliance

Attractive Tax Rates

Minimum Compliance Requirements

Automatic Continuation/ Renewal to next year and Easy to Opt-out

Available for supplier of Goods as well as Services

Less Bookkeeping

* Type of Suppliers	# Aggregate Annual Turnover during FY 2025-26
Supplier of Goods	Taxpayers registered in 08 Specified States upto ₹75 Lakh
	Taxpayers registered in other States upto ₹150 Lakh
Supplier of Services	upto ₹50 Lakh

For more details, please refer to section 10 of CGST Act, Rule 3-7 of CGST Rules and Notification No. 14/2019 - Central Tax dated 07.03.2019

GST Composition Scheme: Big Benefits for Small Taxpayers

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States Focus ■ UCC to be implemented in Assam: Shah



Leaders who ignore workers are not needed, says Naidu

Telugu Desam Party (TDP) supremo and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday said that leaders who ignore party workers are not needed, asserting that the party's strength lies in its cadre. Addressing the gathering at the 44th Foundation Day celebrations of the Telugu Desam Party, Naidu emphasised discipline, commitment, and ideological adherence, noting that only those who perform well will be recognised and elevated as public representatives. "Leaders who ignore or trouble party workers are not needed. Those who work hard will be recognised, protected, and encouraged with positions," said Naidu, stressing that the TDP's victory is the State's victory. Highlighting organisational strength, he said the TDP has a long journey of achievements, sacrifices, and struggles, recalling that many workers laid down their lives, lost properties, and endured hardships for the party.



Vijay names candidates for all 234 TN seats

TVK chief Vijay on Sunday named his party's candidates for all 234 Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu for the April 23 elections, announcing his electoral debut from two seats, including Perambur in Chennai, considered a DMK stronghold. In his maiden electoral battle, Vijay will also contest from Tiruchirappalli (East) in central Tamil Nadu. "It will be C Joseph Vijay from these two seats," the actor-turned-politician announced emphatically amid loud cheers at a meeting of party functionaries held at a five-star hotel in the city. On the occasion, he also named and introduced nominees for the remaining 232 seats, including members of his core team. Reiterating that the electoral contest was between his "people's alliance TVK" and the "Stalin-led alliance", he described the ruling DMK-led bloc as a "patch-up". "I have selected candidates who will stand with the people," he said. "They are not mere 'vetpalargal' (candidates), but 'makkal kappalargal' (people's protectors)," Vijay said, urging voters to extend wholehearted support to them. He particularly exhorted Gen Z voters to turn out in large numbers for the party's 'whistle' symbol and encourage their families to back TVK candidates. "This is a generational electoral battle," he said, claiming the contest was primarily between the DMK and TVK.

Abhishek slams BJP, Humayun Kabir over religion politics



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Abhishek Banerjee on Sunday accused the BJP and Humayun Kabir's Aam Janata Unnayan Party of seeking votes in the name of religion while ignoring basic issues such as livelihood and food.

Addressing a rally in support of the TMC candidate in Naoda Assembly constituency in West Bengal's Murshidabad district, the TMC national general secretary alleged that while the BJP was doing "temple politics", Kabir was indulging in "masjid politics", neglecting issues like development and employment.

"In Murshidabad, while BJP is conspiring to foment riots during Ram Navami processions, Kabir is misleading people in the name of laying the foundation stone of a mosque named after Babri Masjid," he said.

Vowing that he and others would practise religion privately, Banerjee said, "Those who seek votes in the name of mandir or masjid are politically, morally and ideologically bankrupt."

Banerjee claimed that Kabir, who was suspended by the TMC, had a tacit understanding with the BJP leadership and lacked concern for the Muslim community.

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday asserted that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will be implemented in Assam when the BJP comes back to power. He also reiterated that every illegal immigrant must be sent back. Addressing poll rallies in Sonitpur district's Dhekiajuli and Tihu in Nalbari, he claimed that the Himanta Biswa Sarma Government has "freed" 1.25 lakh acres of land that was encroached upon by infiltrators.

He accused the Congress of trying to protect infiltrators and alleged that when the party was in power, it kept the borders porous "in their greed for a vote bank", thereby changing the State's demography. Shaha said that the Himanta Government will ensure no land remains under their control, the former BJP chief said. Shah said that 10 years ago, the BJP had vowed to stop infiltration in Assam and kept that promise.

"However, this is not enough as we have to now send each illegal immigrant out of the country in the next five years," he said. In Tihu, Shah said a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will be implemented in the State in the coming days to "ban four marriages among a particular community".

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma had



Union Home Minister Amit Shah being welcomed at an election rally in Sonitpur, Assam

PIONEER PHOTO

earlier promised to implement UCC in the State if he became chief minister after the Assembly polls.

The State has already passed an anti-polygamy bill, making it an offence that may lead to a maximum of 10 years of imprisonment, barring some exceptions. Uttarakhand is the first State in the country to implement UCC. At the poll rallies, Shah alleged that infiltrators had taken away the employment of the indigenous Assamese youth and seized the food-grains of the poor.

He accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of opposing the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in several states to "protect infiltrators". "We

will not let this happen." The Election Commission of India is trying to weed out infiltrators from the electoral rolls, and the Congress is trying to stop it, Shah claimed.

"But the BJP Government will detect each one of them, delete their names from the electoral rolls and deport them back to the country from where they came," he asserted.

Shah accused Assam Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi of "wanting to protect infiltrators" and asked him to clarify his stand on the issue.

"For years, the Congress kept borders open for infiltrators and, in their greed for a vote bank, changed the State's demography," he claimed, adding that infiltra-

tors have reached different parts of the country from Assam and West Bengal over the years.

Shah said Assam CM Sarma had prevented infiltrators from entering the State from across the border.

Accusing the Congress of doing nothing for the martyrs of the Assam Agitation, he said it was the BJP Government in the State that set up a 'Swahid Smarak' in Guwahati in memory of the martyrs. The Union Home Minister alleged that the Congress, during its rule, did not take measures to safeguard the nation, whereas Prime Minister Narendra Modi took a tough stand against terrorists.

"When terrorists struck

BJP eyes hat-trick in Assam under Himanta, says Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tinsukia (Assam)

The ruling BJP will make a hat-trick in Assam by forming the third consecutive Government in the State under the leadership of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the party's national chief Nitin Nabin announced on Sunday.

Addressing an election rally in support of Margherita candidate and sitting BJP MLA Bhaskar Sharma, Nabin also attacked the previous Congress Governments for allegedly engaging in vote bank politics instead of devel-



oping the State and said there is a need to remember the "black chapter".

"The BJP is going for a hat-trick after the Assembly elections. We first formed the Government under Sarbananda Sonowal's lead-

ership, followed by Himanta Biswa Sarma's tenure. This time, we will form our third Government under the leadership of CM Sarma," he said.

Nabin said that he has been visiting Assam since 2009-10 for various party work and has travelled extensively across the State.

"We need to remember the black chapter. At that time, there was no talk of development at all. There were tensions when I wanted to travel from one location to another. People used to discuss only violence and agitation," he claimed.

Kharge announces five guarantees for Assam



Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge, party leader Bhupesh Baghel, the party's Assam chief and Gaurav Gogoi during a public meeting in Naoboicha on Sunday

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday announced his party's "five guarantees" for poll-bound Assam, with a focus on women's welfare, healthcare for all, land rights and justice in the Zubeen Garg death case.

He also took a swipe at the BJP-led Government in the State, accusing it of indulging in rampant corruption and working "to fill the coffers" of its leaders and their families.

Addressing a rally at Naoboicha in Lakhimpur district, Kharge listed the party's 'five guarantees', which include a monthly cash transfer to women, along with an additional ₹50,000 assistance to women willing to set up or expand a business.

"Our transfer will be unconditional. It will not be like what the BJP Government is doing, where women are asked to be members of their party," he said. The Congress, which is looking to wrest

power from the BJP, pledged ₹25 lakh cashless health insurance for all families, permanent land *pattas* for 10 lakh indigenous people and ₹1,250 per month for senior citizens of the State.

"We also pledge to ensure justice in the Zubeen Garg death case within 100 days if Congress comes to power," Kharge added.

Alleging rampant corruption by the BJP-led Government in the State, the Congress president claimed that even the family members of the party's leaders are involved in it. He claimed that the BJP was "using its 'double engine' in Assam to loot and fill the coffers of its leaders in Delhi".

Hitting out at Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Kharge said that he was a "*nakli* (fake) CM" as the BJP had fought the 2021 elections with Sarbananda Sonowal at the helm. "But after the elections, Sarma removed tribal leader Sonowal to grab the Assam CM's chair," he claimed.

CONGRESS RELEASES FIRST LIST FOR WEST BENGAL POLLS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Sunday released its first list of 284 candidates for the upcoming West Bengal Assembly polls, fielding former State unit chief Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury from Baharampur and ex-TMC MP Mausam Noor from Malatipur. The Congress, which is going solo in the polls for the 294 Assembly seats in the State, announced the names of 284 candidates in one go.



Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury

While Chowdhury has been fielded from Baharampur and Noor, who joined the Congress recently from Malatipur, the party also fielded Madhap Rai from Darjeeling, Abdul Hannan from Sujapur, Susmita Biswas from Dum Dum, Gautam Bhattacharya from Diamond Harbour, Souvik Mukherjee from Asansol Dakshin and Prasenjit Puitandi from Asansol Uttar.

The announcement of candidates came a day after top Congress leaders held detailed deliberations on the list for the upcoming West Bengal assembly elections during the meeting of the Central Election Committee (CEC).

Mamata slams Amit Shah over victim card remarks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Purulia

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday took umbrage over senior BJP leader Amit Shah's apparent remarks about the injury she suffered during the 2021 Assembly polls and asked him to check the medical report, which detailed the extent of the damage to her leg.

While releasing a political "chargesheet" against the TMC Government a day ago, Shah had accused the ruling party's supremo of having "always played the politics of the victim card".

"Sometimes she talks about her injury; sometimes she abuses the Election Commission. But the people of West Bengal now understand her victim card politics

very well," he had said. On Sunday, Banerjee, while addressing an election rally in Purulia district's Manbazar, said, "They are saying that I roam around with a bandage during the polls. I have returned from the brink of death repeatedly. Go and get the report of the doctor."

"Did you deliberately injure my leg during the 2021 elections? I campaigned in a wheelchair. Are you planning to kill me?" she said, sharpening her attack against the BJP. In her address, a day after Union Home Minister Amit Shah released a political 'chargesheet' against the TMC Government, Banerjee said that he should be chargesheeted "for his past deeds". She, however, did not name Shah.



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee gives an address during a public rally, in Raipur village, Bankura district, West Bengal on Sunday

PTI



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Nashik court extends ‘godman’ Ashok Kharat’s police custody till April 1 in rape case



A court in Nashik on Sunday extended the police custody of self-styled godman Ashok Kharat, arrested in a rape case, till April 1. Kharat, who headed a temple trust at Mirgaon in Nashik district and whom several prominent Maharashtra politicians visited over the years, was arrested on March 18 after a woman accused him of raping her repeatedly over three years.

Ten FIRs, eight for alleged sexual assault or exploitation and two for cheating, have so far been registered against him at Sarkarwada police station in the city. The Special Investigation Team (SIT), which is conducting a probe against him, has received more than 100 complaints, most of them from women, over the phone in the last few days, police said on Saturday.

Kharat was produced before the court on Sunday after the end of his previous police custody.

The court asked Kharat whether he had any complaints, to which he replied negatively.

During the hearing, public prosecutor Shailendra Bagde said the investigation in the case was still on and the accused was not cooperating.

The inquiry into the properties of the accused is still to be done. Many women are still coming forward to lodge complaints and the inquiry is yet to be done into the so-called “water” or liquid that Kharat used to give the victims to seduce them before sexually exploiting them, he said. The mobile phone data of the accused has been scanned, and a clone report has been received. An inquiry is to be conducted into whether he saved the names of his contacts – especially political leaders – with dummy identities and many digital evidences are yet to be checked, the prosecutor told the court.

The case is big and others will have to be brought before the accused for the inquiry. Investigators also have yet to determine whether any accomplices were involved in the crime. For all this, Kharat’s three day-custody is needed, he said. The SIT submitted Kharat’s laptops, mobile phone and some documents before the court. SIT officer Kirankumar Suryavanshi also informed the court about the investigation done so far and demanded extension of Kharat’s police custody.

Defence lawyer Sachin Bhate, however, said the SIT was giving the same reasons that had been cited for police custody during the earlier hearing.

What has the SIT done in the investigation to date? he asked, claiming that the probe has been completed and there is no reason to extend the police custody.

On the other side, lawyer M Y Kale, representing a victim, supported the prosecutor’s demand for extension of Kharat’s police custody. The accused has not cooperated and the investigating agency cannot be held responsible for it, he said.

Democracy’s real strength lies in its institutions



PRASHANT
TEWARI

Institutions endure where individuals inevitably fade; they embody continuity, restraint, and collective wisdom beyond the perceptible limits of any single personality. While individuals may inspire, disrupt, or even dominate a moment, it is institutions that preserve order, ensure accountability, and outlast human fallibility. A strong institution does not depend on the virtue of one single leader but is designed to withstand the weaknesses of many; its legitimacy is drawn from process, not personality. As Dr BR Ambedkar wisely cautioned, “However good a Constitution may be, it is sure to turn out bad because those who are called to work it, happen to be a bad lot.” The reverse, too, holds true: even imperfect individuals can uphold justice when bound by strong, principled institutions.

The term “good governance” does not find a mention in the Constitution of India as it was not a part of the common terminology at the time when the Constitution was drafted. However, even a bare, cursory reading of the Constitution and particularly its chapters on Fundamental Rights and the Directive Principles of State Policy make it abundantly clear that the founding fathers of our Constitution had in mind good governance as the objective.

The contemporary use of the term “good governance” began with the World Bank’s 1989 report on “Sub-Saharan Africa: From Crisis to

Sustainable Growth”, where it advanced the argument that economic and social development hinges on the quality of governance. Broadly speaking, the concept of “good governance” has two aspects. The first, which relates to the form of Government, is usually regarded as best exemplified in liberal democracy. The second, which relates to the efficiency of Government, requires that the process of governance be free from corruption and caprice. Effectively, however, these two aspects tend to overlap, because several of the principles that constitute a liberal democracy, such as the rule of law, also contribute to ensuring its effectiveness. As a result, the extent to which a constitution promotes good governance depends to a great extent on its success in establishing a liberal democratic framework.

In a democracy as vast and complex as India, the enduring strength of governance lies not in personalities but in the sanctity and resilience of its institutions. A vibrant democracy does not survive on electoral rituals alone; it rests on a carefully constructed architecture of institutional safeguards.

In India, this architecture includes constitutional and statutory offices such as those of the President, Vice President, Governors, the Prime Minister, the Chief Justice of India, the Cabinet Secretary, and oversight bodies like the Election Commission of India, Lokpal of India, the Central Bureau of Investigation, and the Comptroller and Auditor General of India. These institutions collectively ensure continuity, accountability, and the rule of law, acting as bulwarks

against arbitrariness and excess. The very essence of democratic stability lies in the primacy of institutions over individuals. While individuals may bring competence, vision, or, at times, controversy, institutions are designed to endure beyond transient personalities. The institutions, with their codified powers, established conventions, and constitutional backing, provide a veritable framework within which governance operates. This continuity ensures that even when individuals change, the system remains steady, predictable, and accountable.

Critics often argue that the system occasionally elevates individuals who may appear incompetent or even questionable in integrity. However, this argument overlooks a fundamental strength of institutional design: the ability of systems to moderate individual excesses. Institutional processes, checks and balances, bureaucratic continuity, judicial oversight, and public scrutiny collectively act as correctives. Even a flawed individual, once within the framework of a high constitutional office, is often compelled to operate within clearly defined limits, guided by precedent, law, and institutional memory.

At the same time, public discourse and intellectual critique are indispensable in a democracy. They serve as instruments of accountability and transparency. However, there is a thin dividing line between constructive criticism and systemic erosion. Unrestrained or indiscriminate criticism of institutions—particularly those that form the very backbone of governance—can inadvertently weaken public trust. When institutional

authority is diminished in the public eye, its capacity to deliver effective governance, especially to the last mile, is lamentably compromised.

This calls for a balanced approach. Intellectuals, media, and civil society must continue to question, critique, and demand accountability. But such engagement must be rooted in responsibility and an awareness of the long-term consequences of delegitimising institutions.

The focus should remain on strengthening processes, ensuring transparency, and advocating reforms rather than undermining the very foundations of governance.

It is equally important to recognise that no individual occupies a constitutional office indefinitely. The temporality of tenure is itself a safeguard. Leaders may come and go, but institutions persist with a sense of permanence. This cyclical renewal ensures that no single individual can permanently alter or undermine the character of an institution. Therefore, dissenters, detractors and critics would do well to exercise restraint, keeping sustained pressure on institutions for better performance while preserving their legitimacy.

Ultimately, the survival and success of Indian democracy depend on the collective respect for and strengthening of its institutions. Personalities may shape moments, but institutions shape history.

A mature democracy does not merely react to individuals; it invests in the endurance, credibility, and autonomy of its institutional framework. In doing so, it secures not just governance, but the very idea of the Republic.

Writer is a policy expert and columnist



AIMPLB cautions courts on judicial scrutiny

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB) has told the Supreme Court that courts should refrain from determining what constitutes an “essential religious practice”, cautioning that such judicial scrutiny may amount to encroachment upon the religious freedom guaranteed under Articles 25 and 26 of the Constitution.

The submission is before the nine judges Bench, scheduled to hear the women entry in mosques, certain temples and Parsi temples.

In its written submissions filed in the Sabarimala reference case, the Board argued that identification of the “core” of a religion is inherently subjective and dependent on the beliefs of followers, and therefore unsuitable for judicial determination. The reference arises out of the review petitions filed against the 2018 verdict, which allowed the entry of women of all age groups to the Sabarimala Lord Ayyappa temple. The nine-judge bench will commence the hearing from April 7, on all petitions demanding women entry in Mosques, Parsi temples and Sabarimala Temple.

Muslim Personal Board submitted that the doctrine of Essential Religious Practices (ERP) places an unfair burden on believers to prove that a

particular practice is essential to their faith. Instead, it said, the focus should be on whether State restrictions satisfy the constitutional limitations of public order, morality, and health.

It contended that determining the essentials of a religion involves complex questions of faith, doctrine, and interpretation, which are better left to religious scholars and denominations rather than courts.

The submissions state that judicial determination of essential practices could lead to interference in religious autonomy and dilute the constitutional guarantee of religious freedom. “While dealing with Article 25, to interpret what is religious practice or for that matter, core of the religion within the meaning of essential religious practices, these matters must be left for those who are scholars in religion or the religious denominations and/or the belief of the followers of that particular religion.

Certain practices change with circumstances, like in Hajj manner of Namaz and many other acts commonly done by the followers of Islam get altered completely. The Namaz which is offered at the time of burial of a follower of Islam is completely different from what is offered normally.” The AIPMLB stated that instead of an ERP test, the effort could be to find a



(L-R) Hindu women, muslim women, parsi women

method to lay-down principle to understand the meaning and scope of ‘public order’ and ‘secular activity’ when it comes to matters of religion. In this process, the court shall be dealing with the issue which is secular in nature and not ‘matters of religion. Morality not to be understood solely as ‘Constitutional morality. On the issue of limitations under Article 25, the Board urged the Court to adopt a balanced approach while interpreting “public order” and “morality”.

The submission argued that morality in the context of religious freedom should not be understood solely as constitutional morality but must also take into account the moral principles of the concerned religion, unless those principles are directly opposed to constitutional

values. “As far as ‘morality’ is concerned, for the rights under Article 25, this term should be understood by creating a balance between the moral principle of the religion concerned and the pure constitutional values unless the moral principles of the religion are not 180-degree opposite of the constitutional values, the same should not be touched. The Board also warned that the State should not invoke public order or secular regulation as a pretext to interfere in religious matters without clear legal justification.

“As far as the meaning of morality under Article 25 is concerned, the concept of morality must not be understood as being divorced from religious rights. This Hon’ble Court, on many instances, have interpreted ‘morality’

as ‘constitutional morality’. It is submitted that any interpretation of ‘morality’, whether constitutional morality or some other terminology, must be to uphold rights and not curtail them.” Gender and Religion Cannot Be Treated as Opposing Identities Addressing gender equality concerns raised in the Sabarimala litigation, the Board submitted that gender and religion are not mutually exclusive identities.

The Board submitted that a woman may simultaneously assert autonomy and choose to express her faith through religious practices, and that constitutional adjudication should recognise this coexistence rather than presume conflict between gender rights and religious freedom. Equality in Religious Freedom Must Account for Diversity

The Board further argued that formally neutral policies may produce unequal outcomes across religions because different faiths have distinct practices.

The submissions stated that in a multi-religious society, equality cannot be understood merely as treating all religions identically.

Instead, the constitutional guarantee requires recognition that different religions have distinct practices and obligations, and therefore equal protection must be assessed in relation to the specific practices of each faith.

The Board argued that facial neutrality may conceal unequal effects, particularly where policies or judicial doctrines are structured around assumptions derived from the practices of a majority religion. In such cases, minority practices that do not conform to the same patterns may be placed at a structural disadvantage, even though the rule itself is framed in neutral terms. To explain its position, the Board cited the example of the “sunrise to sunset” regulation governing access to protected monuments. The Board submitted that while the rule is neutral in wording, it may restrict religious observances such as Namaz in mosques located within protected sites, whereas similar restrictions may not affect religious practices of other faiths in the same manner.

Rajasthan HC prohibits night safaris, drone usage in Jawai Leopard Reserve

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

The Rajasthan High Court has prohibited night safaris and the use of drones in Pali district’s Jawai Leopard Reserve, expressing concern over disturbance to wildlife due to unregulated tourism activities.

A bench comprising Justices Sandeep Shah and Pushpendra Singh Bhati directed the State Government to ensure that no safari or wildlife-spotting activity is conducted beyond the prescribed hours of 6 am to 7 pm. The direction came while hearing a public interest litigation filed by a resident, Apoorva Agrawat.

The court noted that such time restrictions are in line with the norms followed at Ranthambore National Park and are necessary to minimise stress and disturbance to animals, particularly during dusk hours.

It further directed author-



ities to strictly prohibit the use of torchlights, searchlights, spotlights, drones or any similar devices for locating or observing wildlife, stating such practices interfere with animals’ natural behaviour and habitats.

The court also ordered that any instance of misconduct by safari operators, hospitality personnel or other individuals, causing harassment or interference with wildlife, must be promptly reported and dealt with expeditiously under the law through appropriate penal and regulatory action.

Delhi HC refuses to halt ED probe against Experion Developers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday declined to grant any interim relief to Experion Developers Pvt Ltd and its co-petitioner in their petition seeking to quash FIR number 64/2026 registered by the Economic Offences Wing, Delhi, for alleged offences under Section 120B read with Section 420 of the Indian Penal Code.

In a significant setback for the petitioners, the Court presided over by Justice Girish Kathpalia expressly refused to stay the investigation. The Court recorded that it was not inclined to stay the probe — noting the nascent stage of the investigation — without first hearing both sides at length. A Status Report has been directed to be filed within four weeks.

The petitioners had additionally sought no-coercive-process relief — effectively anticipatory protection from arrest. The Court refused to grant this relief as well. It merely clarified in procedural terms that pendency of the petition would not



prevent the petitioners from filing separate appropriate proceedings if so advised — a standard observation that confers no substantive protection.

The FIR arises in the context of the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) of Dignity Buildcon Pvt Ltd (DBPL), which owns approximately 9.32 acres of prime land in Sector 62, Golf Course Extension Road, Gurugram — a property independently valued at over ₹630 crore.

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) is investigating whether the resolution process was manipulated to allow the acquisition of this asset at a fraction of its market value through a series

of structured financial flows.

Experion Developers Pvt Ltd (EDPL), the Successful Resolution Applicant under the DBPL CIRP, is alleged to have acquired the corporate debtor — and the land vesting in it — for a nominal consideration of Re. 1 plus ₹47 crore in non-convertible debentures, even as a circular financial flow of approximately ₹445 crore was structured through related entities.

The net economic cost to the acquirer group is alleged to have been negligible relative to the underlying asset value.

Counsel for the ED informed the Court that the FIR — which is only a few days old — is at an early and active stage of investigation. The ED

further disclosed that it has already filed an application before the appropriate forum for recall of the resolution process, though notice on that application is yet to be issued.

Senior Counsel appearing for the petitioners had advanced three preliminary arguments: first, that the ED had no power to cause registration of an FIR; second, that a completed CIRP cannot be reopened as a matter of law; and third, that the FIR does not disclose any cognisable offence. None of these contentions found favour with the Court at the threshold stage. The Court declined to entertain a stay on these grounds without hearing the matter fully, and relisted the case to 14 May 2026.

The petitioners had also alleged that the investigation was being pursued at the behest of competing business entities.

The Court made no adverse observation on the ED’s conduct and proceeded to direct a Status Report — indicating that it finds the matter worthy of a full hearing on merits.

Illegal to conduct age-check test on minor if proper documents are available: HC



Lucknow bench of Allahabad High Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Lucknow bench of Allahabad High Court has said that it is illegal to conduct a medical examination (ossification test) to determine a minor’s age when certificates from a school, board, municipal corporation, municipality, or panchayat are available.

Holding this, the high court set aside the orders of the Juvenile Justice Board and the Special POCSO Court and granted bail to a minor accused of molesting and threatening a 15-year-old girl.

A bench of Justice Manish Kumar passed the order on Saturday on a revision petition filed by a minor.

The case is from Pratapgarh district, where an FIR was lodged with Leelapur police station on March 11, 2025, charging the minor under sections of the POCSO Act and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

It was argued on behalf of the minor petitioner that he was under 16 years of age at the time of the incident.

His high school certificate mentioned his date of birth as January 1, 2010, while his

primary school records stated his date of birth as May 13, 2009. Despite this, the Juvenile Justice Board ordered a medical examination to determine his age, which was upheld by the appellate court of the Special Judge, POCSO Act, Pratapgarh.

Both orders were challenged in a revision petition filed before the high court.

The high court said that, according to Section 94 of the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015, school or board certificates should be considered first for determining age.

Birth certificates issued by municipal corporations, municipalities, or panchayats should be considered next. Only in the absence of these documents, a medical examination can be conducted.

The high court observed that both available documents showed that the accused petitioner was a minor and that ordering a medical examination was against the law.

While granting conditional bail to the minor petitioner, the high court directed him to appear before the district probation officer along with his guardian on the 10th of every month for one year and to stay away from any criminal activity.



Editor's
TAKE

Doomsday for the developing world

It is going to be devastating for developing nations. Those least responsible for climate change are set to suffer its deadliest consequences the most

Peak summer is still months away, but the temperatures in northern India are soaring, and it is getting worse with every passing year. The world is heating up fast, and the temperatures are projected to rise by approximately 1.5 to 2.0 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels by 2050. The report by the Climate Impact Lab has projected that by 2050, ten times more deaths will occur in the Global South due to the rise in temperature than in the West. The developing countries are going to be the worst affected. The heat will result in harsh work conditions, leading to deaths, as the Global South is least ready for it. This natural calamity is unfolding before our eyes, albeit, at a slow pace. The reason for this is twofold. First, most developing countries that constitute the Global South, fall in tropical regions of Africa and Asia, where temperatures have already risen to alarming levels. Secondly, due to low GDP, these countries would not be able to provide better conditions for work like air conditioning, proper hydration and trauma care to their people that can make all the difference in saving lives. In places like India, where summer heat is already intense, additional warming transforms seasonal discomfort into a public health emergency.

Rising temperatures will be traumatic for the people working in fields like farming, construction workers, pavement sellers and the like. What turns heat into a killer is the lack of adaptive capacity. The people in developing countries cannot afford climate control devices due to limited purchasing power. Besides, work conditions are harsh - people working in a heat-intensive environment like brick kilns, bakeries, metal furnaces could be the worst hit. This growing "cooling divide" is emerging as one of the most critical fault lines in the climate crisis. With weak labour protections and informal employment, basic heat safety is not even heard of in these countries, leaving the most vulnerable exposed to heat related issues. Healthcare systems in many of these regions are also ill-equipped to handle the growing burden of heat-related illnesses. Limited access to medical facilities and the absence of a heat-specific response can become fatal. Add to this lack of awareness about the treatment further compounds the problem. The way our cities are developing into concrete jungles and trees becoming extinct in urban landscapes, heat trapped in small ill-ventilated houses that becomes unbearable during the peak heat hours, resulting in dehydration, sun stroke and many other heat-overexposure health disorders. As American Professor Michael Greenstone has pointed out, this represents one of climate change's cruelest ironies: those who have contributed the least to global emissions are the ones who will suffer the most severe consequences. The disparity is also deeply moral, raising urgent questions about global responsibility and justice. Addressing this challenge requires a shift in priorities. Investments in climate adaptation, such as heat-resilient infrastructure and early warning systems, which can significantly reduce mortality. At the global level, the climate finance must become a priority to deal with this impending calamity.

What Om Birla's survival means for Parliament

The failed impeachment motion against Om Birla has done more than reaffirm the numerical strength of the ruling side – it has reignited a debate about the neutrality and resilience of the Speaker's office in India's parliamentary democracy



BHOPINDER
SINGH

The role of the Lok Sabha Speaker in promoting parliamentary stability and independence is incredibly important and deserves recognition. On March 11, 2026, the Opposition's impeachment motion against Speaker Om Birla was defeated by a voice vote, nearly four decades after the last attempt. With 119 MPs signing the notice, the Opposition highlighted the perceived bias in the Speaker's conduct. Removing a Speaker requires at least 272 votes in the 543-member House, and historically, no Speaker has ever been removed. The Speaker is back in his chair.

The repeated challenges to the Speaker underscore political tensions in the legislature, raising questions about the balance of power and mutual respect among legislators. Thus, the Speaker's role is essential to both legislative procedures and the fostering of trust in parliamentary democracy.

Following the unsuccessful impeachment motion, Speaker Birla reiterated his impartiality, asserting that the rules apply equally to all members, including the Prime Minister. He addressed the House to refute allegations of bias. He clarified that there is no mechanism to mute the Speaker's microphone. He emphasised, "This House is not a fair or a festival. We must follow the rules, and no one has the right to speak outside of them, regardless of their position."

Union Home Minister Amit Shah criticised the Opposition for their unruly performance in Parliament, highlighting Rahul Gandhi's low attendance-51 per cent in the 17th Lok Sabha and 52 per cent in the 16th Lok Sabha, compared to averages of 66 per cent and 80 per cent, respectively. The Opposition protested by chanting "Mafi maango," demanding an apology from the Home Minister.

The impeachment motion underscored the ruling party's substantial majority and reinforced the importance of parliamentary procedures. It highlighted the respect that the House warrants for its legislative processes.

Jagadambikka Pal, a member of the BJP panel who presided over the session, called upon the Opposition to resume their seats to facilitate voting. Nevertheless, amid ongoing protests, he chose to conduct a voice vote in the House, which led to the resolution's rejection. The House was subsequently adjourned for the day.

Impeachment motions are infrequent occurrences in the history of India's parliamentary system. The attempt to remove Speaker Birla marks the fourth such effort, underscoring the



IN 1966, MPS
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FEWER THAN 50
MPS SUPPORTED IT

The writer, a military
veteran, is a former Lt
Governor of Andaman &
Nicobar Islands and
Puducherry

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establishes the threshold for removing a Speaker, ensuring that a significant consensus is necessary. During the impeachment debate, Opposition leaders raised concerns about a vacant Deputy Speaker position, faulty microphones, limited speaking rights for Opposition members, and mass suspensions. These issues focus on the challenges facing parliamentary

institutions and the Speaker's office. Union Home Minister Amit Shah criticised the Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, saying he travels for party purposes and publicity rather than

attending parliamentary sessions. "He skipped the President's speech, the Budget, and discussions on Article 370. During key parliamentary sessions, he travels abroad and claims he is not allowed to speak," Shah stated. "According to the established history of this House, its proceedings are conducted based on mutual trust. The Speaker serves as a neutral custodian, representing both the ruling party and the Opposition. It was unfortunate for parliamentary politics that a resolution for the removal of the Speaker has been introduced," he added.

The Speaker's authority underscores the importance of their impartiality and the challenges posed during contentious moments, such as impeachment debates, helping the audience grasp the office's significance to parliamentary stability. Modi, at the end of the impeachment, commended Om Birla for conducting Lok Sabha proceedings with 'dedication, patience and impartiality'. Now that the House defeated the impeachment motion,

Even if the Lok Sabha is dissolved, Speaker Om Birla remains in office until the new House meets and elects a new Speaker.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

inherent challenges of this vital office. The Speaker's position is safeguarded by the House itself rather than the President, and removal can occur only by a majority vote. This underlines the office's independence and its critical role in maintaining parliamentary stability. The previous efforts included a 1954 motion against the first Speaker, GV Mavalankar, and the recent motion against Birla. These incidents highlight ongoing concerns regarding bias and parliamentary conduct.

Since independence, there have been three unsuccessful attempts to remove a Speaker of the Lok Sabha. The first was in 1954 against GV Mavalankar, the first Speaker. The motion was debated on December 18, with Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and Leader of the Opposition AK Gopalan participating. MPs accused Mavalankar of disallowing relevant questions and mishandling adjournment notices.

In 1966, MPs accused Sardar Hukam Singh of obstructing inquiries that could embarrass the government and failing to submit privilege notices. The motion did not advance, as fewer than 50 MPs supported it.

CPI(M) MP Somnath Chatterjee proposed a resolution against Speaker Balram Jakhar. Key participants included Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and P Chidambaram. The House voted against the motion. In the Rajya Sabha, attempts to remove Vice President and Chairman Jagdeep Dhankhar in 2024 have failed. Similarly, the 2020 notices to remove Deputy Chairman Harivansh Narayan Singh did not spark a debate.

The 'Effective Majority' requirement-defined as a majority of all sitting House members-

Why real leadership is forged in discomfort



RACHNA
LAKHPATRI

2ND OPINION

Great managers are not born in leadership courses. They are forged in the uncomfortable decision to put someone else's growth before their own comfort.

Most people collect bosses across a career the way you collect frequent flyer miles – mechanically, without much feeling. Some bosses are efficient. Some are political. Some simply occupy a designation the way furniture occupies a room. And then, rarely, there is one who changes the way a person thinks about work, about themselves, about what it means to be led well. That kind of boss is not common. They are, if honesty is permitted here, almost mythological.

Leadership gets discussed constantly in the corporate world – workshops, books, frameworks, job descriptions that list it between Excel and stakehold-

er management as though it were something you could simply acquire. But real leadership, the kind that quietly redirects a career, that says the hard thing at the right moment, that bets on a person before that person has learned to bet on themselves – that is something else entirely.

What distinguishes a great boss from a merely competent one is this: they are willing to be misunderstood in the short term for your benefit in the long term.

A great boss will push back on an idea in a room full of people – not to embarrass, but because they know the person can defend it and want them to find that out for themselves.

They assign the difficult project, the one that causes lost sleep, because they have seen something that has not yet been seen from the inside. They say no to something wanted badly, and it stings, and three years later the reason becomes obvious. In the moment, it feels like criticism. Sometimes it feels like indifference. But a manager who genuinely cares about someone's trajectory is often the one who makes them uncomfortable on purpose – because comfort, as any honest professional will admit, is where growth goes to retire.

The great boss carries all four, and the balance shifts depending on what the moment demands. On Monday they are the manager, holding the team to a deadline.

By Wednesday they are the mentor, explaining why the deadline matters. When someone walks in looking like the week has already won, they notice before a word is said. And through all of it, they carry a quiet confidence – not in themselves, but in the people around them.

That is the rarest ingredient. Someone who believes in potential before performance has caught up to it. That combination does not come from a training module. It comes from character. The corporate world rewards delivery. It rewards numbers and optics and hitting targets.

The manager who invests deeply in people – who gives honest feedback, who occasionally absorbs criticism on behalf of their team – is doing work that rarely appears in a quarterly review. And so many of them quietly stop.

Not because they stop caring, but because the system was never built to notice. Which is precisely why, when someone finds a boss like that, they remember them for the rest of their career. Not because they were perfect, but because in a world designed to be transactional, they chose to be human. That is not a small thing. That is everything.

The writer is a freelancer and writes on development, social and gender issue

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POWER STILL WEARS MASCULINE FACE

Apropos "When work feminises but power masculinises" (March 28, 2026), the paradox of rising female workforce participation alongside stagnant leadership representation highlights a deeper structural imbalance rather than a temporary social transition. While more women are entering professions across sectors, their presence rarely translates into proportional representation in decision-making roles.

The article rightly points out that the entry of women into the workforce has not dismantled entrenched institutional hierarchies. Authority, leadership, and strategic decision-making continue to be culturally coded as masculine traits, while women are often concentrated in roles perceived as supportive, administrative, or less influential. This is not a deficit of talent, ambition, or competence, but

rather a systemic issue where informal networks, legacy structures, and unconscious bias continue to influence promotions and leadership appointments.

The solution lies not merely in encouraging participation but in reforming institutional frameworks – including transparent promotion criteria, equal parental leave policies, mentorship pipelines, and measurable accountability within organisations.

Unless leadership norms are reimagined to value inclusivity, collaboration, and diverse leadership styles rather than conformity to traditional models of authority, the glass ceiling will persist. Real progress will come not from token representation but from systemic change that normalises women's leadership across all sectors of society.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Leadership in time of war

Amid the intensifying Israel-US-Iran conflict, remarks attributed to Donald Trump – such as suggesting renaming the Strait of Hormuz after himself, dismissing allied military assets as "toys", and making exaggerated claims about oil shipments sent as "gestures" – stand in stark contrast to the heavy casualties across Iran, Israel and Lebanon.

These lighter or offbeat remarks, often delivered alongside serious policy announcements, suggest a leadership style under strain - using humour, bravado, or hyperbole to dominate narratives amid escalating war pressures, economic shocks, and military uncertainty. While political rhetoric has always been part of global diplomacy, the tone and timing of such comments become crucial during periods of conflict and instability. Globally, such statements draw mixed reactions. Allies view them as undermining the gravity of the situation and weakening coordination, while adversaries exploit them for propaganda, reinforcing concerns about the consistency and credibility of US leadership during a widening and volatile conflict. In times of war becomes a strategic tool that can influence diplomacy, morale, and international perception.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

The circular flight experience

The honour this week goes to our favourite airline, Air India. A couple of weeks ago, IndiGo pioneered a new business model: the Delhi-Manchester-Delhi flight that never quite made it to Manchester – a bold innovation allowing travel without the inconvenience of arrival.

Not to be outdone, the national carrier, Air India, decided to raise the bar. Why restrict the experience to one city when you can include several?

Thus was born the Delhi-Vancouver-Delhi and Delhi-London-Delhi experience, where passengers enjoyed long-haul flying, gourmet meals, and the comforting reassurance of landing exactly where they started. No visa. No foreign exchange. No immigration. Just pure aviation bliss and a joyride in the skies.

If this trend continues, travel agencies may soon rebrand these as aerial meditation retreats. The airport operator may even explore tie-ups with parking lots – because clearly, the car never needs to move.

A truly circular economy. The Air India journey may become the most economical international trip where passengers cross continents and oceans yet technically never leave India.

S AKHILESH KRISHNAN | CHENNAI

Landmark ruling on addiction

A California jury found Alphabet's Google and Meta liable for damages in a landmark social media addiction lawsuit that accused the companies of being legally responsible for the addictive design of their platforms. The decision was delivered by a Los Angeles jury after more than forty hours of deliberation across nine days, and over a month after opening statements were presented in the trial.

Among those who testified were Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg and Instagram head Adam Mosseri, although YouTube chief executive Neal Mohan was not called to testify. The plaintiff, referred to as KGM or Kaley, was awarded damages after stating that she became addicted to social media at a young age, which worsened her mental health issues. She began using YouTube at the age of six and Instagram at nine.

Meta argued that Kaley's mental health struggles were separate from her social media use, pointing to her difficult home life. However, the plaintiffs only needed to prove that social media was a substantial factor in causing harm, not the sole cause. The verdict may set an important precedent for future digital platform accountability.

KYASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

A culturally rooted gift, makhana’s global supply chain

We are living through turbulent geopolitics and fragile supply chains. Conflicts and chokepoints have disrupted shipping routes, increased freight costs, and forced buyers to rethink where their food comes from. In such a world, the countries that can supply safe, traceable, climate-smart food reliably will shape the next decade of trade



In Mithila, makhana is not merely a snack; it is memory. It lives in our ponds, our rituals, our kitchens, and the quiet pride of families who have tended wetlands for generations. Today, that same ‘satvik’ tradition is also a modern answer to a changing world-clean, nutritious, plant-based food at a time when global consumers are shifting away from ultra-processed choices.

“From Mithila’s ponds to the world’s platters-Bihar’s makhana can carry India’s values with India’s quality.”

We are living through turbulent geopolitics and fragile supply chains. Conflicts and chokepoints have disrupted shipping routes, increased freight costs, and forced buyers to rethink where their food comes from. In such a world, the countries that can supply safe, traceable, climate-smart food reliably will shape the next decade of trade. This is where Bihar’s makhana can step up-not as a commodity, but as a trusted category.

The government’s core intent: prosperity for farmers, dignity for workers

Let me state the fundamental intent of our policy in one line: makhana must make farmers prosperous, not just make markets excited. The current value chain is still too dependent on hazardous manual work, seasonal gluts, and uneven quality. Our mission is to modernise the entire makhana economy-from pond governance to processing, science to standards, and local clusters to global shelves-so that the farmer captures a fair share of value.

Modernisation means three things: machines, markets, and trust

First, mechanisation as a special lever. Mechanisation will not replace labour; it will replace hardship. Harvesting and seed collection are among the most physically demanding tasks in Indian agriculture. Our 5-year plan commits to field-validated harvesting solutions, delivered through Custom Hiring Centres, with trained operators, technicians, and service entrepreneurs-creating safer jobs for youth and women. Second, markets that reward quality, not just volume. We will



DATA AT A GLANCE (5-YEAR PLAN: 2025-26 – 2030-31)	
What we will deliver	By 2030-31
More production with better practices	Area doubles: 41,000 → 82,000 ha
Export engine	Exports triple: 10,000 → 30,000 MT
Quality & price stabilisation	Hygienic storage scales: 7,196 → 64,058 MT
Jobs with dignity	Jobs rise: 60,205 → 117,034 FTE job-years
Women’s economic participation	Women’s jobs: 19,065 → 39,761; share to 34%
Mechanisation milestone	Harvester available FY 2027-28; scale adoption FY 2028-29

Source: Bihar Makhana 5-Year Action Plan (Refined), 16 Feb 2026; CM review brief tables

strengthen grading, moisture discipline, and hygienic storage so that farmers are not forced to sell in a narrow harvest window. When storage improves, the farmer gains bargaining power; when quality improves, Bihar earns a premium.

Third, trust at global standards. Global buyers do not buy intentions-they buy compliance. We will expand lab access, residue and moisture testing, lot-wise traceability, and retail-ready packaging. The National Makhana Board-launched by the Government of India-will act as mission control, aligning research, standards, and market promotion; and APEDA’s

Patna office brings export facilitation close to the clusters.

Innovation: Turning a traditional crop into a future-ready industry

Modernisation is not only about machines; it is also about ideas.

We will back innovation across the chain: improved varieties and seed systems; safer, energy-efficient popping and processing; new ready-to-eat and ready-to-cook products; sustainable packaging; and circular use of by-products.

The goal is to move from selling ‘loose makhana’ to selling ‘Bihar-branded

makhana’-a product with provenance, performance, and pride.

Women forward by design, not as an afterthought

Makhana’s next growth phase must be inclusive. Mechanisation reduces hazardous manual drudgery; storage and processing create year-round work; and compliance jobs-grading, lab handling, documentation, packaging, and e-commerce-are sectors where women’s SHGs can lead. Our approach is to formalise these roles with training, certification, and credit-so that women are not ‘helpers’ in the value chain, but owners of enterprises within it. “If Bihar wants a stronger

stable ecosystem where farmers, fuel suppliers, and automakers operate with aligned incentives. Consumers can switch between fuels based on price, and investors can plan with confidence.

The underlying principle is simple: long-term certainty unlocks long-term capital.

India now needs a similarly clear roadmap beyond E20-one that signals direction, not hesitation. India’s ethanol push has not been without criticism. Concerns around food security, water use, and efficiency have been raised across sectors. These are important issues and deserve careful policy design. But the larger picture is often overlooked. At 20% blending, ethanol has already reduced crude oil imports, saved valuable foreign exchange, and cushioned the economy against global price volatility. In a world where energy markets are increasingly unstable, this is not just an environmental gain-it is economic resilience.

Ethanol is not merely a blending component. It is a strategic buffer.

To fully realise the potential of biofuels, India must move beyond incremental progress to deliberate scale. This requires a coordinated push across policy, infrastructure, and markets.

First, demand creation must become central. Mandating partial substitution of LPG with CBG-particularly in commercial and industrial segments-can create immediate and predictable demand. Second, infrastructure gaps must be addressed. Investments in compression, storage, and distribution networks are essential to make CBG commercially viable at scale.

Third, policy incentives must reward environmental performance. Linking biofuel production to carbon markets can unlock additional revenue streams and improve project economics.

Fourth, India must expand the scope of ethanol beyond petrol blending. Its use in aviation fuels, industrial applications, and even cooking energy can significantly increase demand.

Finally, a clear roadmap beyond E20-towards E27 and higher-along with accelerated adoption of flex-fuel vehicles, can provide the long-term certainty investors seek. India’s biofuel programme has already delivered measurable benefits-lower imports, cleaner energy, and enhanced rural incomes. But its true potential lies ahead.

Without demand expansion, surplus ethanol will remain underutilised. Without scaling CBG, dependence on imported LPG will persist. Without policy clarity, investment will hesitate.

Energy security cannot be outsourced; it must be built domestically and at scale. Biofuels offer India a chance to turn agricultural strength into energy resilience and reduce external vulnerability. In an increasingly weaponised energy world, biofuels are not just an alternative — they are strategic insurance.

Brazil’s biofuel journey offers a useful lesson in what policy clarity can achieve.

With ethanol blending levels of 27-30% and widespread use of flex-fuel vehicles, Brazil created a

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Digital child sexual exploitation



ARVIND P BHANU

KISHAN PRATAP

The recent conviction and award of the death sentence to a couple by a special POCSO court in Banda, Uttar Pradesh, India, has shaken the conscience of the country. For a decade, a junior engineer and his wife lured children, gave them chocolates, video games and other gifts, and then raped them, filmed the acts, and allegedly produced and transmitted more than two lakh pornographic videos. The brutality began in a rented room in a small town of Uttar Pradesh, but the multinational cybercrime racket, as revealed by the investigating agencies, had buyers of the videos of the rapes of children in dozens of countries. The couple targeted children, including boys who were almost three years old, in multiple districts such as Banda and Chitrakoot. These children were tempted with toys, snacks and chocolates, and later abused and video-recorded.

In the present case, which has been charged under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012, and the Information Technology Act, 2000, it cannot be said that it is merely an issue of perversion in an individual capacity. It can rather be said that the present case is yet another poignant reminder that the sexual abuse of children has reached a critical juncture, wherein the dark web of encrypted chats and anonymous identities plays a major role.

Some child sexual abuse material (CSAM) is being shared through open internet platforms until it is detected and deleted. However, some of it is being shared through encrypted messaging platforms and dark web networks. The dark web is a part of the internet that can be accessed through special software that allows users to remain anonymous. This allows users to remain hidden and creates a black market for such material.

The Banda case, as reported, involved the digital dissemination of such material outside India. This is a common occurrence in dark web environments, where the servers, users and financial platforms are distributed across the globe.

The dark web does not create the abuse; the abuse starts in homes, schools and neighbourhoods. However, the dark web facilitates the abuse by turning acts of cruelty into a global black market.

It is important to clarify a legal point that is often misunderstood. While there may be debate about the issue, watching adult pornographic material in private is not an offence under Indian law. However, browsing or watching any material that contains minors in sexual acts is a serious criminal offence. Sections 13 and 14 of the POCSO Act, 2012, criminalise the use of children in pornographic material, and Section 67B of the IT Act criminalises the publication, transmission, browsing, downloading and possession of sexually explicit material involving children in electronic form.

The Supreme Court’s landmark judgment in Just Rights for Children Alliance v S Harish (2024) resolved a contentious debate on whether viewing or possessing child sexual abuse material amounts to an offence. The Court ruled that viewing or possessing such material, without deleting it or reporting it, qualifies as an offence, noting that “each click perpetuates a chain of exploitation that starts with the abuse of a real child.”

The Court also recommended replacing the term “child pornography” with “Child Sexual Exploitative and Abuse Material (CSEAM)”, emphasising that the language must reflect the reality of abuse.

The urgency is also justified by statistical data. The National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, which operates in association with the Cyber Crime Prevention Against Women and Children Scheme of the Ministry of Home Affairs, has recorded around 1.94 lakh cases of child pornography and sexual abuse-related complaints till April 2024.

However, it is believed that this is just the tip of the iceberg, as the actual number could be much higher. These could include online grooming, sexual abuse, blackmail through morphed images, and sexual abuse threats on social media and dark web platforms. These reports can be filed anonymously with the NCRP. This is an important point because there is a huge amount of shame related to sexual offences. The increasing reports of such offences not only indicate the alarming rate at which such cybercrimes are taking place but also indicate that awareness is increasing. However, the law and enforcement agencies are facing many challenges.

The threat scenario is still evolving with the emergence of AI technology. AI technology has become capable of producing realistic synthetic images and videos depicting children in sexually explicit content. Such images are called AI-generated CSAM. The threat associated with AI-generated images is that they lead to the normalisation of child exploitation, encourage deviant demand for CSAM, and enable blackmail by inserting children’s images into a video or image. Law enforcement agencies all over the world are struggling to understand how AI technology can be regulated in terms of child exploitation

content. The provisions of the POCSO Act and the IT Act are applicable in India in the event of children being used in AI-generated images or being exploited in any manner. But this is not just a court case; this is a case that indicts society. These were not faceless individuals lurking on the Internet. These were individuals in society, mingling with families and children. Child abuse is the grooming of the child before the abuse is reflected on the Internet. Caregivers, parents, and teachers should be aware enough to monitor any unusual behavior changes in the child. There should be integration of online safety in the school curriculum. There should be improvements in the detection capabilities by Internet service providers, with their cooperation in facilitating the quick removal of offending content by the authorities. There should be the use of reporting tools, such as the NCRP, when one suspects online offending. But most importantly, society should not take the issue of “online content” abuse with levity. There is no such thing as harmless child pornography. Each image is a child whose dignity, safety, and future have been violated.

Technology is not evil in and of itself, but it has been a tool that has brought people together, opened doors for new opportunities in education, and helped drive the economy forward. It has also been a tool that, without careful observation, has been the tool that has allowed humanity’s worst attributes to flourish. The dark net, encryption, and technology are not untouchables, but they take cooperation, new laws, and ethical behavior on all sides to achieve that cooperation. India’s laws, buttressed by interpretation in Just Rights for Children Alliance, clearly warn that sexual exploitation of children, whatever form that exploitation may take with technology’s facilitation, is not acceptable.

The laws are part of the solution, but without dealing with the trauma that has been caused, there is not a complete solution. As the Banda case demonstrates, the exploitation could have started in a single room, but the scope of the child sexual exploitation could have been across the globe. The solution to the problem of digital child sexual exploitation is not just about punishing the people who commit the crime, but about dismantling the technology, the economy, and the societies that facilitate the crime in the first place. Combatting Child sexual exploitation in the digital world is not optional; it is a constitutional, moral, and societal imperative.

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VAIBHAV DANGE

The global energy map is no longer defined by markets alone-it is shaped by conflict, coercion, and control. Oil and gas have become instruments of geopolitical leverage, not just economic exchange. From tensions in the Middle East to sanctions and supply disruptions, energy flows today are as political as they are physical.

For India, this reality carries a steep cost. The country imports over 85 per cent of its crude oil and more than half of its LPG. Every global price spike feeds directly into inflation, widens the current account deficit, and strains public finances. Energy insecurity is no longer a distant risk-it is a recurring economic shock.

Yet, hidden within this vulnerability is a strategic opening. India’s biofuel sector-ethanol, compressed biogas (CBG), and biomass-has reached a turning point. What was once a policy experiment is now a credible pillar of energy strategy. The question is no longer whether biofuels can work. It is whether India can scale them fast enough-and smartly enough-to matter.

India’s ethanol blending programme is one of its most notable clean energy achievements. Blending has risen from just 1.5% in 2014 to 20% in 2025-well ahead of schedule. Production capacity has expanded rapidly to nearly 17-18 billion litres annually.

But success has exposed a new fault line. Demand for E20 blending stands at roughly 10-11 billion litres. In effect, a significant share of installed capacity risks lying idle. This is not a failure of supply-it is a failure to expand demand in parallel. If left unaddressed, this mismatch could weaken investor confidence and slow future growth. India has built capacity. It must now create markets. If ethanol represents progress, compressed biogas represents potential.

India currently has over 130 operational CBG plants producing around 900 tonnes per day. While this demonstrates technical viability, it is a fraction of what is possible. India consumes 31-32 million tonnes of LPG annually-more than half of it imported. At current levels, CBG meets well under 1 per cent of this demand.

This gap is not due to a lack of feedstock or technology. It is a function of policy ambition and infrastructure readiness.

CBG can substitute LPG in commercial kitchens, small industries, and transport segments. It can reduce import dependence, create rural income streams, and address waste management challenges. What it lacks is not utility-but scale.

Brazil’s biofuel journey offers a useful lesson in what policy clarity can achieve.

With ethanol blending levels of 27-30% and widespread use of flex-fuel vehicles, Brazil created a

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Instant shocks require immediate remedies, which may be completely wrong, and meaningless. One can dub the central bank’s decisions to force banks to cap their “net foreign exchange positions at \$100 million” to one of those knee-jerk reactions that are laden with good intentions but are likely to result in bad unintended implications. At present, the overall short-term positions are estimated at \$40 billion, and unwinding them immediately can be chaotic, messy, and loss-making. The banks warn that doing so may trigger high mark-to-market losses, as the positions are equated to present prices and rates, and force the unwinding of the trades that may prove profitable in the future. According to the bankers, the central bank needs to give more time to unwind the existing trades. Even better, maybe impose the restrictions on the future, and not existing, trades. This will give ample breathing space.

Obviously, the central bank’s decision to limit the short positions at \$100 million at the end of each business day, starting April 10, stems from fear and scare, possibly political pressures, and as a measure to send the warning signals to the short sellers and speculators. The idea is to protect the rupee, and stop its free fall against the dollar. The fear comes from the fact that despite massive interventions by the central bank, the rupee’s slide continues. It falters for a day or two, and then glides downward. At present, it is nearing ₹95, and has more than doubled against the dollar since Covid (January 2020). The Iran war has further shattered the Indian currency, with the central bank unable to apply the brakes. In fact, the brakes seem to have failed. There is a risk of a downward movement towards ₹100, and higher.

This is where the political pressures make a meaningful entrance. For months, at least since 2025, the official loyalists claimed that a weaker rupee was a good thing for a growing economy. Most nations that grew at frenetic paces at different periods, like Japan in the 1980s, South Korea in the 1990s, and China over a few decades, found that their currencies took a beating as growth escalated. The same was possibly true of India, which has emerged as the engine for global growth. Later, they maintained that a weaker rupee helps exports. But it makes imports expensive, and possibly skews the trade deficit negatively. In the recent past, social media memes have ridiculed the central bank, and regime’s supporters. They quote how the rulers had made fun of the previous regimes when the rupee fell in the past. The currency shoe has begun to pinch politically, and may have repercussions.

But as is natural in such circumstances, and possibly true, the central bank, and the political masters feel that a large part of the rupee’s fall is contributed by short sellers and speculators. The banks indulge in it as it gives them scope to make easy profits. Until the war lasts, the downward pressure on the currency will continue, and any reasonable person will assume a short position, which is hedged, and can be changed when the situation is different. This adds to the pressures. Putting a curb on daily short positions is the easiest, and possibly quickest, way to curb speculation. It sends a warning to the erring banks, institutions, and individuals to stay away, or face drastic and dramatic action. Since the central bank cannot act against the latter two entities, it targets the banks, which are under its control. The banks, forced to unwind rapidly, become the loss-makers.

According to media reports, this is possibly the first time in nearly 15 years that the central bank “placed curbs on the size of bets that banks can take in the currency markets, taking away powers, hitherto, vested with bank boards. The move comes at a time when the rupee is under pressure due to a combination of sales by foreign institutional investors, a rise in the oil import bill, and the overhang of tariffs and visa curbs on exports.” But some experts feel that the step may create more credibility among the speculators that the central bank is unable to protect the rupee, which is likely to fall further, even if the banks are taken out of the equation. Something similar happened with the regime’s energy policy. On the one hand, it categorically announced that there was no energy shortage. On the other hand, it increased LPG cylinder booking time from three to five weeks, imposed windfall taxes on energy exports, raised domestic prices, and lowered excise.

Experience teaches us that ad-hoc, extreme, and knee-jerk actions do not work during crises. In many instances, they accelerate the effects. But policy-makers and regulators cannot lie idle during such times. They need to show their power and strength, and ability to control the situation. Hence, they need to do something, anything. This prompts them to quickly move from denial, everything is normal, stance to the other end, where anything is legitimate. Put the brakes. Increase the curbs. Stop people from buying, using, and speculating. But this turns out to be a bigger nightmare. Even in emergencies what is required to take several steps, but logically, with thought-out implications.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | MARCH 30, 2026

BUSINESS10

From farm loans to retail loans

Are urban households the new highly-indebted farm families?

Recent news items, a book, and few surveys are scary, and dreadful. Retail loans, which include those for personal reasons, consumer purchases, credit card dues, homes, vehicles, and so on, are the major causes for debt headaches of the banks. They account for the largest portion of the annual write-offs due to non-payments. A new book warns that Indian families are in a debt trap, and “carry one of the highest debt burdens in the world... surpassing even consumption-heavy economies like the US, and debt-fuelled growth stories like China.”

Several surveys indicate that Indians are going on a debt binge, not to acquire and build assets like homes, but to pursue aspirations, desires, whims, and fancies. Vacations, which include travel and hospitality, comprise the largest component of unsecured retail loans. Credit purchases stand at just over 10 per cent, but that is only because smart and scared consumers run from pillar to post to roll over credit by paying the minimum balances, and acquire huge interest in the bargain. The loans are, in a sense, ever-greened, and bloated.

Let us start with some of the stark facts. Apart from housing loans, the loans by families, as a percentage of GDP, zoomed by 10 per cent to nearly a third within eight years. In other words, 40 per cent of the annual incomes services the payment of the loans. In 2024-25, as per data given in Parliament, Indian banks wrote off ₹1.72 lakh crore, of which retail (family-linked loans) accounted for the largest share of more than ₹45,000 crore, or more than a fourth. Ironically, the amount was double the write-offs for the farm sector (₹22,000 crore).

According to an official report (December 2024), 45 per cent of the household borrowers are classified as sub-prime, or unable to pay the

loans. More importantly, half of the loans fund consumption, and not investments or productive assets. “The affluent segments of the middle class are borrowing for aspirational purchases like premium smartphone, and lifestyle upgrades, while less affluent households turn to debt for essential needs like healthcare and education,” states the book. In essence, one can segregate household loans as productive (homes, vehicles), future-income (education), lifestyle (bigger TV, better phone), and honour and self-respect (marriages, home renovations).

Unsecured retail loans, which are not backed by collateral, constitute more than half of the written-off retail loans in the last financial year, and private banks contributed more than three-fourths of them. One can assume that such banks, in a bid to boost high-value, high-profit loans (personal loans carry the highest interest), push the products even to those, who may be sub-prime, and unable to pay. This is evident from the unwanted calls for debt and credit cards, as well as personal loans. Worse, this situation emerges despite the central bank’s curbs. Something is clearly not working, and going wrong.

What is crucial is like the Americans not long ago, Indians are saddled with multiple loans, and they juggle incomes to pay them. As demand for loans rises due to multiple desires by multiple members, the end-result is default. Take the case of this three-member Mumbai-based nuclear family, with double incomes, and one kid. At any given point in time, it has an ongoing and sizable EMI for home loan, small one for a laptop or smartphone, and minimum payment(s) to roll-over one or two credit card dues. Bulk bonanza

(gratuity, bonus, and bunched-up increments) clean up the credit cards, or prepay loans.

Even worse is that Indians are not saving. Yes, urbanites transformed into smart investors, and women have taken to mutual funds and stocks, like fish to water. But more importantly, more have turned into consumers, who feel savings is a waste of money. Either use money to grow money, or burn it in the present. Net household savings, as a percentage of income, “hit a 50-year low in FY 2023, and despite rising to six per cent in FY 2025, is still much lower than what it was historically.... Indians have become world champions in borrowing money, lots of it, non-stop, and at high cost,” states the book.

However, one cannot merely blame aspirations. There is real stress as far as family incomes are concerned. Jobs are scarce, especially for the youngsters and first-timers, whose aspirations are as high, or higher than those in the 30s and 40s. Real wages are compressed, which leaves little for discretionary expenses. As access to loans goes up, and payments are easy, despite high interest, debt is the only option. Nuclear families, strained relations, and lack of ‘friends,’ push people to borrow from the banks rather than from close ones. Once the cycle starts, it has a life of its own, an ongoing momentum and motion.

According to the new book, Covid and post-pandemic periods were the major middle-class inflexion debt-points in the recent past. “After this shock, India’s non-housing household debt (i.e., household debt minus home loans) has surged at a rate faster than any of the countries shown in the chart. As a result, India has now surpassed developed countries that are traditionally considered to be consumption heavy (like the US) as well as developing countries that have typically relied on bank credit for development (like China),” states the book.

Two trends will stand out if the debt momentum continues. As is evident now, banks will become safer, and insist on secured loans. Recent data shows that gold loans have emerged as the second-largest ones among retail loans, or higher than unsecured personal loans. But this may be because of the unprecedented, even shocking, rise in gold prices, despite the recent fall since January 2026. Lower loans may enable the banks to correct the massive mismatch between savings and loans, higher credit to industry, families, and farms compared to inflows.

In addition, Indians, especially the younger ones, may either turn into defaulters, and face the consequences for the rest of their lives, or curtail their lifestyle, and kill their dreams for years. The shift from credit cards to only debit cards is visible in some families. Thus, they do not buy the latest gadget, or take an overseas trip that regularly. This makes them, to some extent, hate their lives, when they compare it to their peers, friends, and relatives. Children may become desperate and frustrated, and one is not sure how this will pan out in the future.

The Teck Wrecker

Social ‘lurkers’ better than ‘users’

Do not worry if you are passive and inactive on social media

addressing workshops. Hence, the difference lies between compulsive lurking, and doing it by choice, and deliberately. The latter may be a different feeling, if one browses for information, and yet opt out of the “self-preservation circus.” Research makes a distinction.

A study found that “lurking behaviour is driven by multiple factors, not all of them negative. Some people lurk because of social media fatigue. Some lurk to protect their privacy. And some lurk because they have to get what they need from the platform, information, connection, awareness, without paying the psychological tax....” According to the writer of the piece I read, “That last group fascinates me.... They have kept the first (information function), and discarded the second (performance function).

And when you frame it that way, it starts to look less like passive consumption, and more like an intentional choice.”

I remember that I switched off years ago, maybe 15 years ago, for several reasons. One was the distinction, rightly or wrongly, in my mind that active social media engagement introduces negativity. This happens when a new book you wrote gets five likes, and a new portrait photo of a ‘friend’ gets 878 likes. I wanted to connect with friends who could tell me about interesting articles, fascinating books, and talks and lectures. Instead, I was bombarded with cooked food, holidays, and random thoughts.

Indeed, the image of social media plat-

forms, being in the profession that I am, as a manipulative, money-making, eye-ball-scrouring, and antitrust entities generally pulled me away from them. More so, when my ‘wall’ was bombarded by sponsored content, and of those that the platforms wanted me to follow. I did not want that content. I had to wade through dozens of the unwanted posts before I could reach those by friends. This happened on Facebook’s news feed too. In the end, it became oppressive, meaningless, and bizarre.

One feels that I was right. Recent research shows that “even a one-week reduction in social media use led to significant decreases in anxiety and depression symptoms among young adults (not that I am young by any standards). The lead researcher (in the study) noted that by the third week of reduced use, participants showed a 24 per cent decrease in depression symptoms, and 16 per cent reduction in anxiety. Those are meaningful numbers. And while that study looked at overall reduction rather than lurking specifically, it supports the broader idea that reducing your active engagement... has real psychological benefits.”

According to the author of the piece I read, “stepping back from the performance of social media is not avoidance. For many people, it is a form of self-preservation. Lurking is not laziness. It is a choice to consume without performing, to observe without being observed, and to stay informed without handing your mental energy over to an algorithm that profits from your participation. In a world that rewards noise, choosing silence is one of the most deliberate things you can do.” I agree, although I am not a true lurker, given the ‘likes’ I give.

More importantly, lurking or disengagement on social media give rise to a phenomenon that is possibly most required today. It makes a person stay away from random, immediate verbal-violence bursts that escalate into abuses, and physical violence. In the rage of online disagreements, as happens in the case of verbal fights between couples, and family members, we go overboard, and say things we never should have, or could have. In some cases, the anger, supported by past emotions, makes us act like we never should. As studies and experiences indicate, violence on the streets, and at homes, may stem from social media.

What Does Prosperity Mean? Revisiting Artha for a Rising India

Artha in the ancient Indian political and philosophical thought is a complex and multivalent concept. It has multiple meanings. 'Artha' is derived from the Sanskrit root '??' meaning to acquire, to obtain. It literally means 'that which is sought' or 'purpose'. A deeper foray into classical Indian texts, particularly on statecraft like Kautilya's Arthashastra, the Shanti Parva of the Mahabharata and various Niti shastra works, conceptualise 'artha' within a broader semantic field. Here it includes purpose, meaning, material security and economic resources, pointing to a sophisticated understanding of the relationship between economics, governance and social order. Commonly it is also understood as 'wealth' or 'material prosperity'.

In the classical Indian texts, like Kautilya's Arthashastra, artha is not distinct from politics. It is very much an integral part of sovereign power. The Saptanga (seven limbs) theory is the cornerstone of the conceptualization of state: the ruler (svami), ministers (amatya), territory (janapada), fortified cities (durga), treasury (kosha), army (danda) and allies (mitra). Here the treasury (kosha) and territory (janapada) are the pillars of economics which cannot be isolated from military power and governance.

In the Purushartha theory (human objectives), artha is placed along with dharma, kama and moksha as one of the fundamental objectives of human existence. The Arthashastra says, 'prithiviam labhe sarvam hi prayojanam' (in the acquisition of earth lies all purpose), signifying that in the context of statecraft, beyond individual pursuit, artha denotes the material wherewithal required for the social and political order. Kautilya goes on to say, "sukhasyamulam dharmah, dharmasya mulam arthah, arthasya mulam rajyam." (happiness is rooted in dharma, dharma is rooted in artha, and artha is rooted in the state). This implies that economic prosperity is created through an organised political structure which in turn enables righteous governance.

Kautilya shows a developed understanding of the role of the state in exercising economic authority. The Arthashastra outlines detailed policies for agriculture, trade, monetary affairs and industry. The state appointed officials, for instance Samaharta (chief revenue officer) and official in charge of trade (panadhyaksha) to ensure fair trade practices. There were attempts to standardize currency and regulate lending practices. There is a provision for fining monetary frauds. In fact, the Arthashastra is a precursor



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FORMER ECONOMIC
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MOF, GOI



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to industrial policy with its emphasis on regulation of private craft guilds and state workshops. The idea of dharmartha yuktam i.e. 'the integration of righteousness with material prosperity' is discussed in the Rajadharma Parva of Mahabharata.

Moreover, the Arthashastra establishes the central importance of economic resources for political stability ('rajasya mulam arthah' --wealth is the foundation of the state). However, this is immediately qualified by another verse, 'arthasya mulam rajyam' (the state is the foundation of wealth), signifying that there is a reciprocal relationship between the two and that political authority and economic resources mutually reinforce each other. Kautilya treated the management of income and expenditure as a direct responsibility of the state and the king reviewed it daily. Maintaining a robust treasury was part of Kautilya's financial architecture and played a vital role in monetary policy management. This happens today through the RBI, which also has a treasury function. Instead of delegating the responsibility of constant supervision of officials to his subordinates, the ruler made sure that economic governance was exercised at the

highest political level.

Trade promotion was equally critical to the Arthashastra's economic vision. The taxation was not arbitrary. Revenue needs were balanced with commercial vitality. In this sense, the Arthashastra approaches what may be described as an early administrative model of economic policy, combining regulation, infrastructure support and fiscal oversight into a coherent framework of governance.

For Kautilya, economic prosperity is closely linked with the well-being of the subjects, because the happiness of the king lay in the happiness of his subjects. This can be taken to mean access to health care, education, clean drinking water, nutrition, and employment. A variety of state policy initiatives have endeavoured to convert economic growth into material well-being, social security and risk management for the weakest segments of society. Schemes for food security (Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana), financial inclusion (Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana), housing (Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana), health (Ayushman Bharat) and digital connectivity, direct benefit transfers, formalization of labour, banking and credit facilities are reminiscent of Kautilya's emphasis on the need to maintain granaries, treasuries and multiple revenue streams in order to shield the population from distress: famines, epidemics and political instability. Artha

here is not just wealth creation or fiscal surplus, but the creation of conditions in which secure, dignified, meaningful lives can be led.

The Arthashastra's emphasis on maintaining roads and passes reflects an early statecraft understanding that market integration depends on secure connectivity. This is reflected in modern logistics frameworks such as PM Gati Shakti (emphasis on infrastructure through massive public capital expenditure) and the Golden Quadrilateral (the highway network in India connecting Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai, and Chennai).

Instead of conceptualising prosperity purely in terms of aggregate metrics such as GDP, India offers a template that underscores resilience, equity and sustainability. Cumulatively, all these schemes conceptualise Artha broadly, where the state's authority and its prosperity is defined through the collective prosperity of its citizenry. In this sense, the current governance approach is in continuity with indigenous political thought, illustrating how classical concepts could be reimagined to meet the ethical and material imperatives of a modern nation state.

The sparrows and the elephant (strategy over strength) Panchatantra, Book I

The story of the Sparrows and the Elephant is one of the most popular tales from the Panchatantra. It is found in the first book, Mitra-bheda (The loss of friends).

A pair of sparrows lived happily in a nest built on a tamala tree. The female sparrow had laid her eggs and the arrival of new babies was eagerly anticipated. One afternoon, a wild elephant struck by the heat and his own arrogance began rampaging through the trees in the forest. Upon reaching the tamala tree with a powerful stroke of his trunk, he broke the branch which carried the sparrows' nest. The nest fell to the ground. While the adult sparrows managed to fly away, their eggs were crushed. The female sparrow began to cry inconsolably due to the loss of the unborn young ones. A woodpecker, who was her friend, comforted her by saying that wailing would not bring back the dead and it was essential that justice be served.

The woodpecker realizing that they couldn't fight the elephant alone, called upon his companions, namely, a gnat (fly) and a frog (the chief of frogs). The four small creatures gathered to devise a strategic plan to defeat the trouble making elephant.

The gnat was to fly into the elephant's ear and hum a hypnotic melody. This would make the elephant close his eyes in a trance-like state of mind. Once the elephant's eyes were shut, the woodpecker would peck out his eyes, turning him blind. With the passage of time, the elephant would become dehydrated due to heat. The frog would go to the edge of a deep, rocky pit (far from any water body) and begin to croak at a high volume. Hearing the

croaking frog, the blind elephant would assume the presence of a pond nearby. Following the sound of the frog, he would tumble into the pit.

The plan was executed with absolute precision. As the gnat sang, the elephant closed his eyes, and the woodpecker struck. Visionless and crying in pain, the elephant wandered the forest for hours, searching for water to soothe



his wounds. When he heard the frog's croaking, he rushed toward the sound, thinking he had reached a lake. Instead, he fell into the deep pit and died.

The tiny sparrows had successfully gained victory over the mightiest beast in the jungle.

Moral of the Fable

Even the weak can overcome a powerful enemy if they work as a team using their intelligence. It emphasizes that unity is strength. Unity and team spirit is of utmost importance for a Viksit Bharat.

WISDOM WORD SEARCH

V A N I J Y A T H I K A
O G A L I B M U D R A N
A L V Q M I B H E Y A V
T K A S H R E N I A K I
I P A T G J K L M P N K
V A J R T L S I I A O S
A A T A A V U G A N T I
R Y M I T R L V S Y L K
T R P D E F K H N A Q O
A I A Q P W A L A A D S
K N J K R I S H I S U A
A A D A S D L N M O I W

WORDS TO FIND

Kara , Kosa, Krishi, Mudra, Panya, Rina, Shreni, Sulka, Vanijya, Varta

KARA

- Tax collected for governance and public works.

KOSA

- State treasury supporting administration and welfare.

KRISHI

- Agrarian foundation of the economy.

MUDRA

- Certified monetary system facilitating exchange.

PANYA

- Trade commodities circulating across markets.

RINA

- Structured credit and borrowing practices.

SHRENI

- Merchant and artisan guilds maintaining trade ethics and financial cooperation

SULKA

- Trade toll ensuring regulated commerce and state revenue.

VANIJYA

- Professional and long-distance commerce activity.

VARTA

- Classical economic activity including agriculture, cattle economy, and trade.

Marvels of India

SURYA MANDIR, KONARK

A Marvel of Ancient Indian Astronomical Ingenuity:

The Sun Temple at Konark stands as a striking example of Bharat's synthesis of science, architecture and symbolism. Built in the 13th century on the Odishan coast, it is designed as a giant stone chariot dedicated to the Sun God, reflecting deep astronomical insight.

Astronomical Precision and Solar Alignment: The temple is oriented along an east-west axis, allowing the first rays of the rising sun to illuminate its entrance and sanctum during key moments such as solstices and equinoxes. This alignment demonstrates a refined understanding of the solar movement that was crucial for ancient calendrical systems and ritual timings.

Ingenious Timekeeping Mechanism: Its 24 intricately carved stone wheels function as sundials. The spokes cast shadows that enable precise measurement of time, from hours down to minutes, across seasons, thereby showcasing mastery over solar geometry.

Civilisational Significance: More than a place of worship, the temple foregrounds Bharat's advanced engagement with astronomy and mathematics, embodying a civilisation where scientific knowledge and sacred expression coexisted seamlessly.

Did you know?

Did you know? The Ayyavole-500, a powerful medieval South Indian merchant guild from Aihole, operated across Asia between the 8th and 14th centuries. They managed extensive trade networks, financed production, standardized commercial practices and even maintained private armies to guard pepper and silk shipments across the ocean. They were also major donors to temples and provided loans to local artisans and farmers. In many ways, they functioned like early multinational corporations and mobile banking systems, centuries before modern economic institutions emerged.

QUIZ

Economy, Commerce & Finance

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 "Kosh Mulo Dand" is the official motto of the Income Tax Department of India in Sanskrit. In which famous ancient text are these words found?	Arthashastra	Brihatsamhita	Shukranitisar	Yajnavalkya-smriti
2 Which are the dynasties that first introduced superior cavalry with better horse breeds, reins, saddles and stirrups to India?	Nandas & Mauryas	Sungas & Kanvas	CHOLAS AND PANDYAS	Sakas and Kushans
3 Which Satavahana King is known for his love for overseas trade and navigation, whose coins also depicted a ship on them?	Gautamiputra Satakarni	Vashishtiputra Pulumavi	Yajna Sri Satakarni	Simuka
4 Which of these was a Land Tax levied by the Cheras or Keralaputras from the Tamil Sangam period?	Karai	Vetti	Sungam	Iravu
5 India since ancient past has had trade relations with countries on land as well as sea routes. What is the 11th century Sanskrit text Yukti Kalpataru, written by King Bhoja of the Paramara dynasty particularly known for?	Monsoons & Climate	Maritime Piracy	Shipbuilding Tech	Sea Routes

Answers: 1 - A, 2 - D, 3 - C, 4 - A, 5 - C

hitopadesha

The Monkey Who Pulled Out a Wedge

1

2

3

4

5

6

Once upon a time, a writer decided to build a temple in his city. While the work was in progress, a carpenter sawed a log in half, put a wedge in between so that it would stay apart and went for lunch.

It so happened that a group of wandering monkeys came to this spot and began to play about, on and around the logs.

One of the monkeys sat on the half-split log, put both his legs into the gap and tried to pull the wedge out.

Suddenly, out came the wedge and the log closed in, trapping the monkey's legs and crushing them.

MORAL OF THE STORY: It is not wise to poke one's nose into another's affairs.

FROM THE

WORLD

US

New submarine joins Naval fleet

The USS Massachusetts officially joined the Navy fleet after a commissioning ceremony, making it the first submarine named after the Bay State. The newest Virginia-class fast attack submarine, which can dive to depths greater than 800 feet, was christened on May 6, 2023, by the ship's sponsor, Sheryl Sandberg, the former COO of Meta. This is the 25th Virginia-Class submarine co-produced by General Dynamics Electric Boat and Newport News Shipbuilding and the fifth US Navy vessel named after Massachusetts. "To be able to take a ship from new construction and watch it be built together by the ship yard, train with our team and bring into Boston Harbor for the first time, it's very amazing," the sub's commanding officer.

NEPAL

Oli remanded in 5 days custody

Nepal's former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli was remanded in judicial custody for five days by the Kathmandu District Court on Sunday, even as protests continue to erupt in various parts of the country over the arrests. Oli and former home minister Ramesh Lekhak were arrested on Saturday for their alleged involvement in suppressing the Gen Z movement of September 8 and 9 last year, in which 76 people, including around two dozen youths, were killed. The arrests came a day after the newly formed Balendra Shah government decided to implement the report of the probe commission into the Gen Z protests in its first cabinet meeting. Lekhak was presented before the district court seeking remand for ten days to carry out further investigation into their alleged involvement in the incidents of killings. He was also remanded in custody for five days.

Racial bias allegations in jury makeup as US top court set to hear death row case of Black inmate

MARK SHERMAN
Washington

Certain names will be familiar to the Supreme Court in the latest case involving a Black death row inmate from Mississippi, with arguments set for Tuesday. Doug Evans, a now-retired prosecutor with a history of dismissing Black jurors for discriminatory reasons, knocked all but one Black person off the jury that tried and convicted Terry Pitchford. Judge Joseph Loper allowed it to happen. The state Supreme Court upheld the conviction. Just seven years ago, in a case involving



the same district attorney, trial judge and state high court, the Supreme Court overturned the death sentence and conviction of Curtis Flowers because of what Justice Brett Kavanaugh described as a "relentless, determined effort to rid the

jury of Black individuals." Seven of the current nine justices were on the court then. The Supreme Court has in recent years taken a dim view of defendants' claims in capital cases, especially in the last-minute efforts to stave off execution. The court in December agreed to hear Pitchford's appeal relating to a claim of racial discrimination that, in other cases, has gained traction even among some conservative justices. Pitchford was sentenced to death for his role in the 2004 killing of Reuben Britt, the owner of the Crossroads Grocery, just outside Grenada in northern

Mississippi. Pitchford, 40, was 18 when he and a friend went to the store to rob it. The friend shot Britt three times, fatally wounding him, but was ineligible for the death penalty because he was younger than 18. Pitchford was tried for capital murder and sentenced to death. The case has been making its way through the court system for 20 years. In 2023, US District Judge Michael P Mills overturned Pitchford's conviction, holding that the trial judge did not give Pitchford's lawyers enough of a chance to argue that the prosecution was improperly dismissing Black jurors. (AP)

Jerusalem heads into subdued passover, Easter under shadow of Iran war

MELANIE LIDMAN
Jerusalem

Jerusalem's major religious sites are shuttered and families are dejected and exhausted ahead of Passover and Easter as the Iran war enters its fifth week. The mood stands in stark contrast to a usual spring, when longer days herald a period of family gatherings and an influx of tourists for the major Jewish and Christian holidays. Metal shutters are drawn on nearly all stores in the Old City, home to key holy sites, and only scattered footsteps echo on deserted stone alleyways. Vast plazas are missing



the typical throngs of faithful and tourists. Jerusalem has largely escaped past wars, with Israel's enemies appearing to be hesitant to launch missiles near the city's Muslim holy sites. But since Israel and the

US launched strikes on Iran on February 28, Jerusalem has repeatedly come under fire. Earlier this month, an intercepted Iranian missile sprayed shrapnel on the rooftop of the Greek

Orthodox Patriarchate, just steps from the Church of the Holy Sepulcher, one of the most important sites in Christianity. The church, built on what is revered by many Christians as the site of Jesus' crucifixion, burial and resurrection, remains closed under Israeli military guidelines prohibiting gatherings of more than 50 people. Missile debris also hit a road leading to the Western Wall, the holiest site where Jews can pray. From his office overlooking the plaza at the Western Wall, now closed to worshippers, Rabbi Shmuel Rabinowitz, lamented the empty plaza. The heart aches

greatly, it bleeds, seeing the Western Wall as it looks now," he said. The massive priestly blessing for Passover, which usually draws tens of thousands, will take place with just 50 worshippers, Rabinowitz said. That's the maximum allowed to pray together in the enclosed area by the Western Wall under wartime safety guidelines - reminiscent of the restrictions imposed during the coronavirus pandemic. Easter celebrations cancelled The Latin Patriarchate has cancelled a procession on Sunday commemorating Jesus' triumphant entry into Jerusalem, the Christian cel-

ebration known as Palm Sunday. Any other year, tens of thousands of Christians from around the world would walk down the narrow, hilly streets toward the Old City, waving palm fronds and singing. Rami Asakrieh, the parish priest for Jerusalem's Catholics, said the community will sorely miss the procession, a deeply emotional and spiritual part of the holiday. But the cancellation is also a reminder that faith comes internally from the heart, not from external actions, he added. "We are celebrating resurrection, resurrection is from death and winning the pain and the war," he said. "It will

not come by having fear, but by having faith." A local Catholic high school, empty of students as classes have been cancelled, was also recently hit by debris from an Iranian missile interception, Asakrieh said. A Franciscan priest, Asakrieh is still celebrating Mass for up to 50 parishioners at the Saint Savoir monastery's cavernous marble hall, near the centuries-old complex's music school, the Magnificat Institute. The school was built in what was once the convent's basement, which has been approved by the Israeli military as a suitable shelter. (AP)

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Israel and the US are "working in very close coordination" to respond after Yemen's Houthi rebels said they had launched missiles toward Israeli targets, Israel military spokesperson Col Nadav Shoshani told reporters on Sunday. He declined to provide details on operations against the Iran-backed group, which controls parts of Yemen, but said Israel had grown accustomed to confronting repeated attacks from the Houthis, who have for more than two years launched missiles and drones toward Israel and shipping targets in the Red Sea. He also said Israeli mili-

tary statements about nearing completion of top-priority strikes did not mean it was running out of overall targets. "There are many more groups of targets and there are also many more targets when it comes to (ballistic missile) production," he said. The Israeli military on Sunday said it has completed a new wave of attacks on Iran, hitting targets in Tehran and other parts of the country. It also claimed Iran launched several missiles targeting locations in Israel, saying residents in "relevant areas" have received warnings and air defences are working to intercept the incoming fire. Qatari TV



Catholic worshippers carrying their children on their shoulders as they march in a procession during a Palm Sunday Mass in Beirut, Lebanon. The poster in the background reads in Arabic: "Honor, sacrifice and loyalty" AP

Saudi, Egypt and Turkiye FM in Pak to discuss West Asia tensions

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Foreign Ministers of Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Turkiye are in Pakistan on Sunday to attend a two-day quadrilateral summit organised to find a way to de-escalate the ongoing conflict in West Asia. Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan arrived in Islamabad on Saturday, while their Saudi counterpart Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud reached here on Sunday at the invitation of Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar. The summit is Pakistan's attempt to broker peace in West Asia. Dar

Meeting of the Foreign Ministers of Saudi Arabia-Pakistan-Turkey and Egypt



held bilateral talks with his counterparts from Egypt and Turkiye on Sunday on the sidelines of the summit. He is expected to hold talks with his Saudi counterpart separately as well. During the visit, the leaders will hold consultations on regional developments and also call on Prime

Minister Shehbaz Sharif, the FO added. In a press statement on Saturday, the FO said the visiting foreign ministers will hold "in-depth discussions on a range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in the region". Separately, the FO in a mid-night post on X said that Dar held a telephonic conversa-

tion with Iran Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and "discussed the evolving regional situation and ongoing developments". Dar said that he emphasised the need for de-escalation, stressing that dialogue and diplomacy remain the only viable path for lasting peace. In a related development, Dar announced Iran agreed to allow 20 more ships under the Pakistani flag to pass through the Strait of Hormuz. Iran controls the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which the world's 20 per cent of energy is transported. Since the conflict, very few ships are allowed by Iran to cross it. "I am pleased to share a

great news that the Government of Iran has agreed to allow 20 more ships under the Pakistani flag to pass through the Strait of Hormuz; two ships will cross the Strait daily," he said. "This is a welcome and constructive gesture by Iran and deserves appreciation. It is a harbinger of peace and will help usher stability in the region," he added. In the post, the Pakistan foreign minister tagged US Vice President J D Vance, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, US Special Envoy to the West Asia Steve Witkoff and Araghchi and concluded it by saying that "dialogue, diplomacy, and such confidence-building measures are the only way forward". (PTI)

Dissanayake thanks PM Modi for fuel shipment

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Colombo

Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake on Sunday thanked PM Narendra Modi for sending an oil shipment to ease the fuel supply disruptions in the Island nation caused by the West Asia conflict. A shipment of 38,000 MT of fuel, comprising 20,000 MT of diesel and 18,000 MT of petrol, arrived in Colombo, as an emergency support through the local operation of Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Lanka IOC (LIOC). "Spoke with PM @narendramodi a few days ago

about the fuel supply disruptions Sri Lanka is facing due to the West Asia conflict. Grateful for India's swift support. 38,000 MT of fuel arrived in Colombo yesterday," Dissanayake posted on social media. The Sri Lankan President also thanked External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar for his support. "My thanks also to EAM @DrSJaishankar for his close coordination", he said. Sri Lanka also held talks with Jaishankar to seek assistance on energy sustainability in view of the volatile situation in West Asia.

Extreme weather claims 17 lives in Afghanistan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kabul

Severe flooding, a landslide and thunderstorms in parts of Afghanistan left 17 people dead and 26 injured over the last 24 hours, with more heavy rainfall predicted, authorities said Sunday. The number of casualties could increase as crews from the country's National Disaster Management Authority survey the affected areas, the authority's spokesman, Yousuf Hammad, said in a statement. Thirteen of Afghanistan's 34 provinces, mostly in the western, central and northwestern parts of the country, were affected. The severe weather also left 147 homes either completely or partially destroyed, wiped out 80 km of roads and destroyed agricultural land and irrigation canals and businesses, Hammad said. In all, he said, 530 families were affected. Heavy rainfall was also forecast to affect eastern and central parts of the country Monday, and

Hammad warned flooding was also possible in those areas. The disaster management authority warned residents to avoid river banks and areas at risk of flooding in those regions, and ordered local officials to be on standby to provide assistance. Earlier this year, heavy snowfall and flash floods left dozens of people dead across the country. Afghanistan is highly vulnerable to extreme weather events, with snow and heavy rain that trigger flash floods, often killing dozens, or even hundreds, of people at a time. In 2024, more than 300 people died in springtime flash floods. Decades of conflict, coupled with poor infrastructure, a struggling economy, deforestation and the intensifying effects of climate change have amplified the impact of such disasters, particularly in remote areas where many homes are built of mud and offer limited protection against sudden deluges or heavy snowfall.



Iranians cross into southern Iraq for cheaper groceries, internet

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Iranians crossed into southern Iraq via the Shalamcha border on Sunday, hours after an airstrike hit the Iranian side, cutting power and halting trade for several hours, said Haider Abdul Samad, the crossing's deputy director. The strike, not the first since the war began, occurred around 3 am, he said, without providing any details on casualties or the strike. Electricity was restored and trade resumed by mid-morning, but Abdul Samad said such disruptions have become routine amid the



ongoing war. Cross-border movement has significantly declined, though dozens of Iranians continue to enter Iraq seeking cheaper goods, internet access and brief family visits before returning to nearby cities such as Abadan and Ahwaz. Many described the US-Israel strikes

and frightening but said they would not leave. "There is no reassurance. We don't know when our homes could be targeted," said Razzak Saghir Al-Mousawi, 71, who entered Iraq from Iran on Sunday. "I am definitely afraid," he added.

Indian arrested in UK after car rams into pedestrians, injuring seven

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
London

An Indian-origin man has been arrested on suspicion of attempted murder after seven people were seriously injured when a car drove into pedestrians in England, police said on Sunday. The incident occurred on Saturday at 9:30 pm in a city centre street, Friar Gate, Derby, after a car crashed into pedestrians. The police confirmed that seven people were injured in the incident. "The car, a black Suzuki Swift, struck several people in Friar Gate at about 9.30 pm on Saturday, 28 March," a statement from Derbyshire police said. "A man in his 30s, who is originally from India, was found a short time after the incident," it said. "He remains in police custody," it added. The city police have still not revealed the identity of the Indian-origin man arrested on suspicion of attempted murder.



North Korea tests new missile engine

HYUNG-JIN KIM
■ Seoul

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un observed a test of an upgraded, high-thrust, solid-fuel engine for weapons and hailed it as a significant development to boost the country's strategic military capability, State media reported Sunday.

While the test was in line with Kim's stated goal of acquiring more agile, hard-to-detect missiles targeting the United States and its allies, some experts speculate North Korea's claim may be an exaggeration.

The Korean Central News Agency reported Kim watched the ground jet test of the engine using a composite carbon fiber material. It said the engine's maximum thrust is 2,500 kilotons, up from about 1,970 kilotons reported in a similar solid-fuel engine test in September.

KCNA reported the test was conducted as part of the country's five-year arms build-up meant to upgrade "strategic strike means," a term referring to nuclear-capable ballistic missiles and other weapons.

Kim said the latest engine test had "great significance in putting the country's strategic military muscle on the highest level," according to KCNA. KCNA did not report exactly when or where the test occurred. North Korea's report on the latest test could be "bluffing" as it

didn't disclose some key information like the engine's total combustion time, said Lee Choon Geun, an honorary research fellow at South Korea's Science and Technology Policy Institute.

When North Korea described the September test as the ninth and final ground test of a solid-fuel engine that it earlier said would be used for intercontinental ballistic missiles.

Observers predicted at the time North Korea would soon test-launch an ICBM loaded with that engine, but it hasn't done so yet.

North Korea's solid-fuel engine development program may be facing some delays or the country might have determined to develop a better engine,

In recent years, North Korea has test-fired a variety of ICBMs demonstrating the potential range to reach the US mainland, including missiles with solid propellants that make detection prior to liftoff more difficult.

The country's older liquid-fuel missiles must be fueled before liftoffs and cannot last long. Some of North Korea's past claims about major weapons test-launches drew outside scepticism. In 2024, North Korea claimed to have successfully tested a multi-warhead missile, but South Korea quickly dismissed the claim as deception to cover up a failed launch.

Some foreign experts say North Korea still faces technological hurdles before it has a functioning ICBM, such



possibly with Russian technical assistance, Lee said.

Cooperation between the countries has deepened in recent years, with the North sending troops and conventional weapons to support Russia's war against Ukraine.

as ensuring its warheads survive the harsh conditions of atmospheric reentry.

But others dispute that assessment given the number of years the country has spent on its nuclear and missile programs. (AP)

Police arrest Nepal former energy minister

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Nepal police on Sunday arrested former energy minister and Nepali Congress leader Deepak Khadka in connection with a money laundering case, local media reported.

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police took Khadka into custody on Sunday morning. The Himalayan quoted CIB spokesperson Shiva Kumar Shrestha as saying.

The police detained Khadka for investigation after receiving a request from the Department of Money Laundering Investigation, The Kath Mandu Post reported.



During the Gen Z protest last year, images and videos had surfaced showing burnt fragments of banknotes at

the residences of Khadka and former prime ministers Sher Bahadur Deuba and Pushpa Kamal

Chinese artists stage dance drama based on *Ramayana* in Beijing

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

A group of Chinese dancers have staged "Adi Kavya - The First Poem", a dance drama based on the translation of *Ramayana* by noted Chinese scholar professor Ji Xianlin.

The drama, directed by Chinese Bharatanatyam exponent Jin Shanshan, featured a cast of over 50 local performers and was held at the old Indian Embassy premises.

Outgoing Indian Ambassador Pradeep Kumar Rawat along with officials of the embassy attended the event. Rawat, who will retire later this month, will be suc-



ceeded by the current Indian Ambassador to the UK Vikram Doraiswami.

According to organisers, about 200 people, mostly Chinese and Beijing based diplomatic community took part in the event.

This is the third time the dance drama was staged in

Beijing. It was first staged in January last year.

The embassy last year also organised a symposium on "Sangamam-A Confluence of Indian philosophical traditions" in which noted Chinese scholars spoke on *Bhagavad Gita* and Indian civilisational values. (PTT)



Demonstrators holding up their banners as they march across the Memorial Bridge during a No Kings protest in Washington

AP

No Kings rallies draw crowds across US, Europe

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ St Paul (Minnesota)

Large crowds protested Saturday against the war in Iran and President Donald Trump's actions in "No Kings" rallies across the US and in Europe.

Minnesota took center stage, with thousands of people standing shoulder-to-shoulder to celebrate resistance to Trump's aggressive immigration enforcement.

Minnesota's flagship event on the Capitol lawn in St. Paul drew Bruce Springsteen as its headliner. He and other speakers praised the state's people for taking to the streets over the winter in opposition to a surge of U.S. Customs and Immigration

Enforcement agents.

Springsteen performed "Streets of Minneapolis," the song he wrote in response to the fatal shootings of Renee Good and Alex Pretti by federal agents. Springsteen lamented Good and Pretti's deaths but said the state's pushback against ICE has given the rest of the country hope.

"Your strength and your commitment told us that this was still America," he said. "And this reactionary nightmare, and these invasions of American cities, will not stand."

People rallied from New York City, with almost 8.5 million residents in a solidly blue state, to Driggs, a town of fewer than 2,000 people

in eastern Idaho, a state Trump carried with 66 per cent of the vote in 2024. Big, but mostly peaceful, crowds

US organisers have estimated that the first two rounds of No Kings rallies drew more than 5 million people in June and 7 million in October.

This week they told reporters they expected 9 million participants Saturday, though it was too early to tell whether those expectations were met.

Organisers said more than 3,100 events, 500 more than in October, were registered, in all 50 states.

Protests were mostly peaceful, but federal authorities deployed tear gas "due to demonstrators throwing

large concrete blocks, bottles and other objects" in downtown Los Angeles, police said on the social platform X.

LAPD also said protesters were later arrested for failing to disperse.

Earlier in Topeka, Kansas, a rally outside the Statehouse had people impersonating a frog king and Trump as a baby. Wendy Wyatt drove with "Cats Against Trump" sign from Lawrence, 20 miles to the east, and planned to drive back to her hometown for a later rally there.

Wyatt said "there are so many things" about the Trump administration that upset her, but "this is very hopeful to me."

Mexican Navy locates missing Cuba aid boats

ANDREA RODRIGUEZ
■ Havana

Two sailboats that went missing carrying humanitarian aid from southern Mexico to Cuba landed in Havana on Saturday afternoon hours after Mexico's navy said it had located the boats days after they went incommunicado because of bad weather.

The vessels carrying at least eight people departed from Isla Mujeres in southern Mexico on March 20 and then lost contact, fuelling concern in Mexico, Cuba and beyond.

In a post on X on Saturday morning, the navy said an aircraft spotted the boats 80 nautical miles northwest of Havana, Cuba. Upon arriving to the island, Adnaan Stumo,

the coordinator of the sailing convoy, said bad weather was responsible for the delay because the boats had to take a longer route and the sailors were "never in any serious danger."

He thanked Mexico's navy, which escorted one of the boats into Havana Bay, for its support and making sure they were OK, and said they were "delighted" to start delivering aid to Cubans on the island.

"We arrive with a simple but powerful message: solidarity with the Cuban people doesn't stop at borders. It crosses oceans," Stumo, a US citizen, said.

"Over the past week, our sailboats encountered difficult conditions at sea, during which we lost



contact with convoy coordinators and maritime authorities alike."

The organization Nuestra America Convoy said Friday that based on the speed of the vessels reported to the Cuban maritime authorities,

Oil spill deals economic blow to fishermen in Gulf of Mexico



FELIX MARQUEZ
■ Veracruz (Mexico)

Every year, fish markets in the seaside Mexican city of Veracruz flood with a crush of customers in the lead up to Holy Week. This year, they were virtually empty.

That's because a huge oil spill off the Gulf of Mexico has spread more than 373 miles across the ocean and seeped into seven nature reserves.

Mexicans who have worked in Veracruz's booming fishing industry for years say they've been dealt a blow at one of the busiest times of the year.

Markets usually jammed with customers were desolate on Friday, with some vendors loudly promoting their products in a desperate attempt to attract customers. Fishing has declined off the coasts of the seaside states of Veracruz, Tabasco and Tamaulipas since the spill.

"This is our livelihood," said a worried Miguel Lopez Rojas, owner of one of the fish stalls in the popular market.

Authorities in the country said that the spill originated from a vessel anchored off the coast of the port city of Coatzacoalcos in Veracruz state and two "natural seepages." (AP)

European Union plans to increase deportations

SAM MCNEIL/GIADA ZAMPANO
■ Brussels

The European Union is expanding its powers to track, raid and deport migrants to "return hubs" in third countries in Africa and elsewhere, quietly adopting tactics of the Trump administration that have drawn public criticism across the 27-nation bloc.

The EU continues to tighten migration policies after right-wing parties took power in some countries in 2024. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, from the centre-right European People's Party coalition, has said the new measures will prevent a repeat of the 2015 crisis caused by the civil war in



Syria, when about one million people arrived to seek asylum.

"We have learnt the lessons of the past. And today, we are better equipped," von der Leyen has said. The new policies, known as the Pact on Migration and Asylum, go

into effect on June 12.

Far-right parties in Europe have praised the deportation policies of US President Donald Trump and called for the EU to adopt a similar approach.

Human rights groups warn that authorities are already illegally pushing

Pope Leo rejects war justification in Palm Sunday message

NICOLE WINFIELD
■ Rome

Pope Leo XIV on Sunday rejected claims that God justifies war and prayed especially for Christians in the Middle East during a Palm Sunday Mass before tens of thousands of people in St. Peter's Square.

With the US-Israeli war on Iran entering its second month and Russia's ongoing campaign in Ukraine, Leo dedicated his Palm Sunday homily to insisting that God is the "king of peace" who rejects violence and comforts those who are oppressed. "Brothers and sisters, this is our God: Jesus,

King of Peace, who rejects war, whom no one can use to justify war," Leo said. "He does not listen to the prayers of those who wage war, but rejects them."

Leaders on all sides of the Iran war have used religion to justify their actions.

US officials, especially Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth, have invoked their Christian faith to cast the war as a Christian nation trying to vanquish its foes with military might.

Russia's Orthodox Church, too, has justified Russia's invasion of Ukraine as a "holy war" against a Western world it considers has fallen into evil. Palm Sunday marks



Pope Leo XIV presides over Palm Sunday Mass in St Peter's Square at the Vatican

AP

Jesus' triumphant entrance into Jerusalem in the time leading up to his crucifixion, which Christians observe on Good Friday, and resurrec-

tion on Easter Sunday.

In a special blessing at the end of Mass, Leo said he was praying especially for Christians in the Middle East

who are "suffering the consequences of an atrocious conflict. In many cases, they cannot live the rites of these holy days." Earlier Sunday, the Latin Patriarchate said Jerusalem police prevented the Catholic church's top leadership from entering the Church of the Holy Sepulchre. It was the first time in centuries that church leaders were prevented from celebrating Palm Sunday at the place where Christians believe Jesus was crucified, the Patriarchate said.

Leo said that during Holy Week, Christians cannot forget how many people around the world are suffering as Christ did. "Their trials

appeal to the conscience of all. Let us raise our prayers to the Prince of Peace so that he may support people wounded by war and open concrete paths of reconciliation and peace," Leo said.

A Holy Week that recalls Pope Francis' suffering When Holy Week opened last year, Pope Francis was still recovering at the Vatican after a five-week hospital stay for double pneumonia. He had delegated the liturgical celebrations to others, but rallied on Easter Sunday to greet the faithful from the loggia of St. Peter's Square. Most poignantly, he then made what became his final pope-mobile loop around the

piazza. Francis died the following morning, Easter Monday, after suffering a stroke. His nurse, Massimiliano Strappetti, later told Vatican Media that Francis had told him: "Thank you for bringing me back to the square" for the final salute.

During his 12-year pontificate, Francis famously celebrated the Holy ritual by travelling to Rome-area prisons and refugee centres to wash the feet of people on society's margins. His aim was to drive home the ritual's message of service and humility, and he would frequently muse during his Holy Thursday homilies, "Why them and not me?" (AP)

Mongolia ruling party picks new PM candidate

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ulaanbaatar

Mongolia's ruling party selected a new candidate for prime minister on Sunday after the last head of Government, Zandanshatar Gombojav, resigned after only nine months on the job.

Uchral Nyam-Osor, the current party chairman who is serving as speaker of the Parliament, was nominated at a meeting of the Mongolian People's Party, according to state news agency Montsame. Uchral first joined the MPP in 2009, and is seen as a compromise candidate amid different party factions.



Uchral Nyam-Osor

Zandanshatar's resignation came after one of his senior ministers faced allegations of corruption. He also faced a political boycott from the opposition Democratic Party, which has refused to attend parliament sessions since earlier this month, citing concerns over a concentration of power within the ruling party.

The turmoil is likely to exacerbate distrust in the Government.

▼PROSPECT

NCLAT rejects BSE pleas on Demat account freezing during insolvency



The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has dismissed the appeals filed by BSE, where the leading bourse challenged the power of the NCLT to defreeze the Demat accounts of businesses undergoing insolvency resolution and liquidation process. A two-member NCLAT bench said the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has the jurisdiction under section 60 (5) of the Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC) to entertain applications for defreezing of the Demat accounts during insolvency and pass a direction also. "...the impugned orders have been passed in valid exercise of such jurisdiction," the NCLAT said while setting aside the two petitions filed by BSE.

BSE had contended that the NCLT does not have any jurisdiction under Section 60 (5) of the IBC Code to adjudicate on the issues, which are within the Securities Law Framework and SEBI Circulars. The issues pertain to two companies - Future Corporate Resources and Liz Traders and Agents - where their Demat accounts were frozen by BSE due to default committed by them in paying the annual listing fee, among others, as non-compliance with LODR Regulations and unpaid dues from fines levied for such non-compliance. The Resolution Professionals/liiquidators of both the Corporate Debtors (companies facing CIRP) approached the NCLT after BSE refused to defreeze the Demat accounts of these companies, as they intended to sell the shares held in those accounts and to recover money from the proceeds of such sale.

AIRIA to host India Rubber Expo

The All India Rubber Industries Association (AIRIA) will host the 12th edition of the India Rubber Expo 2026 from April 7 to 10 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, positioning the Capital as a hub for global rubber industry engagement. Touted as Asia's largest rubber industry exhibition, the four-day event is expected to attract over 400 exhibitors and nearly 45,000 trade visitors from around 14 countries, alongside dedicated international pavilions. Industry stakeholders including manufacturers, traders, and machinery companies will converge to showcase innovations, explore partnerships, and assess emerging market trends. The event will run alongside the International Rubber Conference (IRC) from April 7 to 9. AIRIA President Anay Gupta said the upcoming edition will bring together leading players and experts from across the value chain. "With expanded scale and global outreach, IRE 2026 will act as a catalyst for innovation, partnerships, and sustained growth in the rubber industry," he added.

Jio Fin Services expects to begin life, general insurance business in 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Jio Financial Services (JFS) is hoping to start general and life insurance businesses this year, a top company official has said.

The financial services company does not have any immediate plan to get into the unsecured and consumer durable lending businesses.

"We hope to start insurance manufacturing in 2026, subject to regulatory approvals," its chief executive and managing director Hitesh Sethia told PTI recently.

The company, which recently entered the reinsurance business, along with its equal joint venture associate Allianz, will partner with the French company for general and life insurance businesses as well.

Sethia said in parallel, the company is working towards building the necessary teams



for the insurance foray.

JFS, which is promoted by entities linked to the richest Indian Mukesh Ambani, has entered lending businesses, like assisting home buyers, asset management, wealth management and reinsurance, either by itself or through partnerships.

Explaining its strategy in the lending business, Sethia said JFS also has its own boundaries based on risk and capital, and at present, it is concentrating on serving

Vedanta chief claims Jaypee asset bid reversal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mining baron Anil Agarwal on Sunday claimed Vedanta had received written confirmation that it had won a bid for a Jaypee Group asset, but the decision was subsequently reversed, without elaborating on the reasons.

In a social media post, Agarwal said Vedanta was "declared the highest bidder publicly" to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) through the insolvency process. Attaching a source-based media report about the price opening meeting of lenders of the insolvent real estate company on September 5, Agarwal said, "It was a transparent process. We were informed in writing that we had won".

"But life is never so simple. After some days, the decision was changed," he added.

Billionaire Gautam Adani's group was the only other bidder for JAL, the flagship company of the Jaypee Group.

The Committee of Creditors (CoC) of JAL evaluated the rival bids and subsequently went to the insolvency court NCLT for approval of the Adani bid.

The NCLT's Allahabad bench approved the bid, against which Agarwal's Vedanta group has filed a



Anil Agarwal and Gautam Adani

challenge before the appellate body NCLAT.

National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), in the second hearing last week, did not stay NCLT's decision approving Adani's bid for the JAL. Agarwal said he did not want to go into the details of the reversal of his group's winning bid. "That is for the right forum" to decide.

Agarwal said the episode brought back memories of his interactions with Jaypee group founder Jaiprakash Gaur, who had earlier expressed a desire that the group's assets be passed on to "safe hands" and carried forward with the right intent.

"We have no attachment to

this asset. If it comes, it is God's grace. If it goes, that is also his wish," he said, adding that commitments made in line with "dharma" should not be taken back.

He said Vedanta would present facts through appropriate channels and follow due process, drawing on teachings from the Bhagavad Gita. JAL, which has high-quality assets and business interests spanning real estate, cement manufacturing, hospitality, power and engineering & construction, was admitted to insolvency in June 2024 after it defaulted on payments of loans aggregating ₹57,185 crore.

In November last year, the

CoC approved the resolution plan by business tycoon Adani to acquire JAL.

Adani Enterprises got the maximum 89 per cent votes from creditors, followed by Dalmia Cement (Bharat) and Vedanta Group.

The CoC, however, defended its decision, saying the process complied with all insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) rules. They maintained that no bidder has a guaranteed right to win, even if it offers the highest value.

They said plans were evaluated on multiple factors, including upfront cash, feasibility, and execution, not just headline value.

Adani's bid was preferred

as it offered around ₹6,000 crore upfront and faster payments within two years, compared to Vedanta's longer payment timeline of up to five years.

Lenders also rejected Vedanta's revised offer, saying it was submitted after bidding had closed and accepting it would require restarting the process. They added that all bidders were given equal opportunity and multiple chances to improve their bids.

Earlier this month, on March 17, the NCLT approved Adani Enterprises Ltd's Rs 14,535 crore bid to acquire JAL through the insolvency process. This was challenged by Vedanta before the NCLAT.

On March 24, the NCLAT declined any interim stay over the Vedanta Group's plea against the order passed by the NCLT approving the bid by the Adani Group to acquire JAL.

The NCLAT two-member bench sought a response from the CoC of JAL within a week. It listed the matter on April 10 for the next hearing.

The Vedanta group has filed two appeals before the NCLAT. In the first one, it has challenged the validity of the resolution plan, and in the second one, it has challenged the approval of the plan by the CoC and the adjudicating authority (NCLT).

During the proceedings of

the NCLAT on March 24, counsel representing Vedanta contended that it was declared the highest bidder by JAL's Committee of Creditors.

Vedanta's bid value was ₹16,726 crores, and Adani Enterprises' bid was ₹14,535 crore.

The CoC's discretion in the selection of a resolution plan must be exercised only in line with the applicable law and the governing documents, Vedanta's counsel contended before the NCLAT.

Jaypee Group firm JAL has major real estate projects like Jaypee Greens in Greater Noida, a part of Jaypee Greens Wishtown in Noida (both on the outskirts of the national capital), and the Jaypee International Sports City, located near the upcoming Jewar International Airport.

It also has three commercial/industrial office spaces in Delhi-NCR, while its hotel division has five properties in Delhi-NCR, Mussoorie, and Agra.

JAL has four cement plants in Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, and a few leased limestone mines in Madhya Pradesh.

It also has investments in subsidiaries, including Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd, Yamuna Expressway Tolling Ltd, Jaypee Infrastructure Development Ltd, and several other companies.

Airport360 Expo 2026 to spotlight India's aviation boom as passenger traffic heads toward 300 million

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's aviation sector is entering a decisive expansion phase, with passenger traffic projected to reach 300 million domestic travellers by 2030 and commercial aircraft fleets expected to nearly double to around 1,100 aircraft by 2027. Against this backdrop, Airport360 Expo 2026 will be held on April 23-24, 2026 at the Bombay Exhibition Centre, Mumbai.

The event will bring together airport operators, airlines,

aviation authorities, technology providers and infrastructure developers to examine the next phase of airport development and passenger mobility in India.

The exhibition is expected to host over 2,200 attendees, 50 plus exhibitors and over 100 aviation professionals and decision makers, along with participation from over 10 countries including Germany, Nepal, Bangkok, Singapore, Oman, positioning the event as a key industry platform for collaboration across the global aviation

value chain.

Placing the exhibition in the context of India's aviation growth trajectory, Taher Patrawala, Managing Director, Media Fusion, said, "India's aviation sector is witnessing one of the most dynamic growth phases globally. Over the next two decades, the industry will require close to 37,000 pilots and 38,000 maintenance technicians, highlighting the need for coordinated innovation across infrastructure, technology and human capital."

West Asia crisis: CII outlines 12 point industry agenda; commends Govt response

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Industry body CII on Sunday commended the Government for its "swift, coordinated and well-calibrated response" to the disruptions arising from the West Asia crisis, and laid out a 12-point agenda for India Inc to complement these efforts.

CII Director General Chandrajit Banerjee said while the policy response has mitigated immediate risks, the evolving situation requires continued coordination between the Government and industry.

"The policy approach has correctly focused on maintaining production continuity and supporting viable enterprises," Banerjee noted. "The next phase requires industry to build on this foundation



with practical and responsible actions."

Banerjee emphasised that the Government's response has been timely, measured and reassuring.

It reflects a whole of Government approach that has focused on keeping supply chains functional, supporting exporters, protecting households and maintaining macroeconomic stability.

Foreign investors dump record ₹1.14 lakh crore in March on West Asia conflict

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Foreign investors have pulled out ₹1.14 lakh crore (about \$12.3 billion) from domestic equities in March, making it the worst monthly outflow, weighed down by escalating tensions in West Asia, a weakening rupee and concerns over the impact of elevated crude oil prices on India's growth.

With one trading session still remaining in the month, the outflows could extend further. The previous record for the highest monthly exodus stood at ₹94,017 crore in October 2024.

With the latest withdrawals, total foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) outflow has reached ₹1.27 lakh crore so far in 2026, according to NSDL data.

As per the data, FPIs have remained persistent sellers throughout March, offload-



ing equities worth ₹1,13,380 crore in the cash market till March 27.

The sharp sell-off follows a strong rebound in February, when foreign FPIs pumped in ₹22,615 crore, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

Market participants attributed the sustained selling pressure to global macroeconomic headwinds and heightened geopolitical

uncertainty. VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, said the weakness in global equity markets following the war in West Asia, the steady depreciation of the rupee, fears of decline in remittances from the Gulf region and concerns surrounding the impact of high crude prices on India's growth and corporate earnings contributed to the sustained

selling by FPIs.

Additionally, the selling has been driven by a combination of elevated US bond yields and tightening global liquidity, which have improved the relative attractiveness of developed market fixed income, Himanshu Srivastava, Principal - Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, said.

While Indian market valuations have corrected alongside the recent market decline, they continue to remain relatively elevated compared to several emerging market peers, which may still be prompting selective profit booking and reallocation, he added.

Moreover, FPIs were sellers in other emerging markets, too, like Taiwan and South Korea. There is a risk-off trend in equity markets globally after the war broke out in West Asia.

Planters' body ask Assam Govt to address 'administrative' concerns for providing land patta

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Planters' body, Tea Association of India (TAI), has urged the Assam Government to address its concerns regarding the transfer of housing line land to workers under a new amended law.

While appreciating the Government's intent to provide land patta to the tea garden workers, it called for clear guidelines in the matter so that the "administrative" concerns are taken care of.

Speaking at the 37th Biennial General Meeting of TAI, Assam Branch in Jorhat on Saturday, TAI president Shailja Mehta said the concerns of the industry should be considered before implementation of the new law.

She pointed out that in many cases, tea garden land

is mortgaged as collateral with banks, and transfer may create financial and legal complications. Further, the Land Ceiling Act applies only to land and not to company-built assets such as labour quarters.

"Adequate compensation should therefore be ensured under the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act 2013," Mehta stressed.

The TAI president also pointed out that under the Occupational Safety Health and Working Conditions Code 2020 (earlier Plantations Labour Act 1951), management remains responsible for housing and welfare amenities.

"Transfer of land without corresponding legal amend-



ments may lead to continued liability on management. We therefore sincerely request the State Government to address these issues before implementation," she added.

Echoing her, the chairman of Assam branch of TAI G S

Pahwa said, "Our concerns that arose were more administrative in nature given the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Condition Code. We look forward to clear guidelines from the Assam Government as to how to

amalgamate the two legislations for the benefit of the industry and the state."

"We respectfully submit that balanced and consultative policymaking will best serve the long-term interests of tea garden workers and the tea industry," the chairman added.

TAI president Mehta further said the recent changes under the four Labour Codes implemented from November 2025 are likely to significantly impact the tea industry, where nearly 60 per cent of the cost of production is labour-related.

She said that the code on wages limits the recognition of in-kind benefits to 15 per cent of total remuneration for minimum wage calculation.

However, as the tea industry bears substantial responsibility for providing welfare

benefits in kind, the TAI has urged that all in-kind benefits be fully recognised for wage computation purposes.

Mehta also requested the Government to release all pending subsidy payments under the Assam Tea Industries Special Incentive Scheme (ATISIS 2020), as the Finance Department has issued a notice that the benefits will be disbursed only subject to annual budget availability, with no carry-forward provision.

The TAI president also expressed apprehension that the country's tea export could face "pressure" if the ongoing geopolitical tensions in the region continue, especially the closure of the Straits of Hormuz.

She said the country's tea exports had performed "exceptionally well in 2025,

reaching a record level of about 280 million kg, with export earnings rising to nearly ₹8,488 crore."

It was largely supported by strong demand from key markets such as Iran, Iraq, United Arab Emirates and China, and a significant portion of the growth was driven by increased exports of Orthodox teas to the Middle East, which continues to remain a crucial destination for Assam teas.

"However, the ongoing geopolitical tensions in the region are a matter of concern. Any disruption in these traditional markets could affect export volumes, payment cycles, shipping routes, and price realisations," Mehta said.

"Amidst reports of closure of Straits of Hormuz, the prospect of Indian Tea

exports do look grim as of now," the TAI president added.

She stressed that, given the industry's growing dependence on these destinations in recent years, there is a genuine apprehension that India's export performance in 2026 may face pressure if the situation persists.

"In this context, there is a need for continued policy support and market diversification efforts to safeguard the momentum achieved in tea exports and protect the interests of producers," Mehta stressed.

Among measures sought by the planters' body is minimum sustainable price for Made Tea, address quality issues, including that of low-cost imported teas, promotion of Indian Teas, and agritech innovation.

BRIEFLY

US team gets a dressing down from Belgium



Belgium gave a dressing down to a US team with big World Cup dreams. The Americans allowed five straight goals in a deflating 5-2 loss to the Red Devils in a friendly on Saturday night. The US had not lost by three in a home game in which it scored the opening goal since an 8-1 defeat to England in 1959, according to Opta. "We cannot arrive with the wrong idea of that we are so good, we are so handsome, we are so well dressed and we are Americans," said US coach Mauricio Pochettino, a former Argentina defender. "Always after the games when the team wins, (it's) because we fight, we were aggressive, we were intense, yes? When we drop in that intensity – we saw today." Preparing to host the World Cup this summer, the US entered with a five-game unbeaten streak and Pochettino's message to players had been they can win soccer's top title for the first time. Weston McKennie's 39th-minute goal from Antonee Robinson's corner kick put the 15th-ranked US ahead of the world's No. 9 team. But then the US level lagged. "We didn't defend our box well enough," said Matt Turner, who returned to the US goal for the first time since June.

Canada battles back to tie Iceland 2-2



Jonathan David scored twice from the penalty spot in the second half before Tajon Buchanan was shown a red card as Canada battled back from a 2-0 deficit to salvage a 2-2 draw with Iceland in an international men's soccer friendly on Saturday. Buchanan was sent off in the 80th minute for an elbow to the head of Iceland midfielder Mikael Egill Ellertsson as the ball was rolling out of play. The sequence marked the third straight game, and fourth time in the last eight, Canada has seen red. "We're physical, we play hard, but we're not a dirty team," said Canada coach Jesse Marsch, who disagreed with Buchanan's dismissal. "I'm not worried about developing a reputation, but certainly cards like that can change momentum in tournaments." Orri Steinn Oskarsson had both goals for Iceland. The 29th-ranked Canadians are preparing to co-host this summer's World Cup with the United States and Mexico, while Iceland – No. 74 when FIFA's last official list was released in mid-January – failed to qualify. Oskarsson took advantage of a bad pass from Canadian centre back Kamal Miller before moving in alone and beating goalkeeper Dayne St. Clair in the ninth minute for a 1-0 lead. The striker for Spanish club Real Sociedad doubled the advantage in the 21st after Ellertsson beat right back Niko Sigur to a ball in midfield. Oskarsson took a quick feed on the run and steadied himself before another nice finish.

Tiger Woods is facing an uncertain future

DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Stuart (USA)

Tiger Woods got out of jail and into the passenger seat of a dark SUV, his face as vacant as his mug shot as he was driven away to a future again filled with so much uncertainty.

The next step legally is facing charges of driving while intoxicated, damage to property and refusal to submit to a urine test, which led to him spending eight hours Friday in the Martin County jail some 15 miles from his home on Jupiter Island, Florida. His manager at Excel Sports, Mark Steinberg, did not respond to a request for comment Saturday on Woods' arrest. As for golf, this comes at a bad time for the



sport's most influential player.

Woods had said earlier in the week he was trying to get in shape for the Masters on April 9-12, though that was looking unlikely. He turned 50 at the end of last year. "This body, it doesn't recover like it did when it was 24, 25," Woods said earlier this week. He also was days away

Kimi Antonelli wins Japanese Grand Prix

STEPHEN WADEAP
■ Suzuka (Japan)

Italian 19-year-old Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes has won his second consecutive Formula 1 race, taking Sunday's Japanese Grand Prix ahead of Oscar Piastri of McLaren. Antonelli finished a comfortable 13.7 seconds ahead of the Australian.

Charles Leclerc of Ferrari was third with George Russell of Mercedes in fourth. McLaren's Lando Norris was fifth with sixth for Lewis Hamilton of Ferrari at the Suzuka circuit in central Japan on a clear, sunny spring afternoon. Antonelli won the first F1 race of his career two weeks ago in China, the

second-youngest winner in history. The youngest was Max Verstappen in 2016 at only 18. The young Italian also won from pole-position in China, the youngest to ever claim that spot.

Antonelli has 72 points in three races and now becomes the youngest to ever lead the season drivers' standings. "It's too early to think about the championship but we're in a good way," Antonelli said. "I got a terrible start, I just need to check what happened."

"Definitely it's been (the starts) a weak point this year and I need to improve that because you can easily win or lose races with that," Antonelli added. Mercedes



continue to dominate Russell was second in China two weeks ago and won the season-opening race in Australia, which means Mercedes has victories in the first three races of 2026 - and Antonelli has two of them. Antonelli started from

the pole with Russell alongside, but neither got a great start with Piastri beating both to the first turn and holding the early lead.

Antonelli's and Mercedes again showed they are best at mastering the new car configuration for 2026, which fea-

Sabalenka beats Gauff to win Miami Open

MARC BERMAN
■ Miami Gardens (USA)

Aryna Sabalenka beat Coco Gauff in the Miami Open women's singles final 6-2, 4-6, 6-3 on Saturday.

The world No. 1 overpowered fourth-ranked Gauff in the first and third sets with sizzling groundstroke winners and became the first player to accomplish the 'Sunshine Double' – winning Indian Wells followed by Miami in the same season – since Iga Swiatek in 2022.

It was Sabalenka's second straight title at the Miami Open, Gauff's hometown tournament, and put her ahead of Gauff in their head-to-head record, 7-6. "You've pushed me to be a better



player," Sabalenka said during the ceremony, before adding about the crowd, "You always bring a full stadium." The match lasted 2 hours, 11 minutes and ended on Gauff getting broken for the fourth time

with a wide backhand.

Gauff fought back to force the third set, but couldn't maintain the momentum she appeared to get from the deafening crowd supporting her. "It sucks not to come out with a better result but I had a lot of joy this week," Gauff said to the crowd. "You guys brought energy every day this week." Sabalenka at times was frustrated by the fan noise, including when someone yelled "out" during a long rally. She used a curse word at the fan and the chair umpire warned the crowd, but also gave a code violation to Sabalenka.

"I shouldn't be that rude, but come on, you cannot do that," Sabalenka said at the ceremony. "So let's agree

we were both wrong, so sorry." Gauff's off-and-on serve created seven double faults while Sabalenka registered none. Sabalenka broke Gauff in the first game of the third set, helped by a Gauff double fault and an unforced error. On break point, Sabalenka crunched a backhand winner. "I was disappointed about that first game of the third set up 30-0 with momentum," Gauff said.

"It was an important game to win in that moment." The match was attended by Kai Trump, President Donald Trump's granddaughter and a golfer at the University of Miami. She posted a photo with Sabalenka at the tournament on social media Friday.

Indian boxers seek strong start in Asian meet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia)

Indian boxers will aim for a good show at the Asian Championships, beginning here on Monday, as they look to make the most of their opportunities in a packed season and secure direct berths for the multi-sport events later this year.

The tournament marks the first major outing in a loaded season that includes the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow (July-August), the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan (September-October) and the World Boxing Cup Finals in Uzbekistan.

Apart from the medal rush, the championships assume added significance as finalists will earn direct



qualification for the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, in line with the Boxing Federation of India's selection policy.

The Indian team has been acclimatising in Mongolia for the past 15 days, training in multinational camps and

sparring with boxers from Mongolia, China, Jordan and Thailand. The women's challenge will be led by Olympic medallist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen (51kg), reigning world champions Minakshi Hooda (48kg) and

Jaismine Lamboria (57kg). While Lovlina comes in after a gold-winning effort at the Boxam International in Spain in February, it will be the first international outing since November for Zareen, Hooda and Jaismine. "These Asian Championships will be a strong test. We know that Asian boxing has improved the level over the last decade, many of the world's strongest teams are in Asia," women's head coach Santiago Nieva told PTI.

"Our history tells us that we can win medals. So, we are targeting several medals, but for us it is important to have people in the final, and there's not many times we've had more than one gold, and obviously a gold medal makes a difference."

Weightlifter Isak overcomes injury concerns to clinch KITG glory

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

On the verge of quitting weightlifting after losing both his parents before he was 16, Mizoram's Isak Malsawmtluanga overcame a back injury to clinch the men's 60kg gold medal at the Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG) here. Isak came up with a strong showing in the clean and jerk, after finishing the snatch section in second place, to clinch the gold medal with a total of 235 kg and was immediately embraced by his uncle, who has been the guiding force behind the teenager.

The personal tragedy had left the 18-year-old devastat-



ed but the support from his childhood coach and his uncle and aunt salvaged his sporting career.

Isak's father Heming Malsawmtluanga had died in a bike accident in 2018, the same year he began training to become a weightlifter. This meant that the only

son in the family was left wondering whether he should continue to train or focus on earning money and support the family.

"At that time my childhood coach Soma motivated me a lot and asked me to continue weightlifting," Isak told SAI Media.

Japan's 1-0 victory over Scotland

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Glasgow

Japan coach Hajime Moriyasu hailed his team's tactical flexibility after a late Junya Ito strike secured a 1-0 victory over Scotland in a pre-World Cup friendly at Hampden Park, leaving the home side facing a chorus of boos.

In a key warm-up for their eighth successive World Cup appearance, the Samurai Blue overcame a bright Scotland start to dominate the second half. Substitute Ito proved the difference in the 84th minute with a clinical finish from 12 yards to settle a tight contest. While Scotland manager Steve Clarke admitted he was "surprised and disappointed" by the nega-



tive reaction from the Tartan Army, Moriyasu focused on his side's defensive discipline and late clinical edge.

"I am very pleased to play in such a fantastic atmosphere," Moriyasu said. "It was a tough game and we managed to keep a clean sheet. Toward the end, we changed the setup to get the

goal. It was great for building confidence." The visitors survived an early scare when Zion Suzuki pushed a Scott McTominay effort onto the post, but Japan gradually asserted control. Kodai Sano clipped the bar before the break, and the pressure eventually told when Ito got the breakthrough.

Mary Kom considers move into professional boxing

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Olympic bronze medallist and six-time world champion Indian boxer M. C. Mary Kom on Sunday said she is considering a move into professional boxing.

The 43-year-old, who became the first Indian woman boxer with an Olympic medal when she won bronze in the 2012 London Games, is past the age eligibility to compete on the amateur circuit.

"What can I say about the high points? Winning six World Championships was incredible. Although I reached a stage where age restrictions prevented me from competing further in



amateur boxing for the country, a new opportunity has surfaced in professional boxing," she said on the sidelines of Sundays on Cycle event. "I am currently taking some time to consider it. I am working hard and trying to make a comeback to show

people what I can still do.

Widely considered one of the greatest amateur boxers, Mary Kom also underlined her commitment to grassroots development through her academy in Manipur.

"Personally, I am very involved with my academy.

I travel back and forth quite often, sometimes it becomes difficult due to the current situation in Manipur; things can get tough there.

"However, I remain deeply committed. Even when I can't be there physically, I manage and oversee the academy through phone calls. My dream is to stay fit for as long as I can, regardless of age," she said.

As India eyes hosting major global events such as the 2030 Commonwealth Games and possibly the 2036 Olympics, Mary Kom stressed the importance of sport in building international recognition. "Sports development is absolutely essential. Without sports, it is difficult for a country to build a global

reputation. Sports are what propel a nation forward," she said. She also praised government efforts to strengthen sports infrastructure and promote talent identification, particularly through initiatives such as Khelo India and Fit India Movement.

"While we shouldn't compare it directly to the scale of the IPL yet, boxing infrastructure has improved significantly, the government has introduced fantastic facilities through movements like Khelo India and Fit India. There is a growing concern for fitness across the nation now." Kom highlighted the inclusion of tribal youth in national programmes, pointing to developments in Chhattisgarh.

Rohit, Rickelton’s blistering fifties power MI to 6-wicket win over KKR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Mumbai Indians rode on blistering half-centuries from former skipper Rohit Sharma (78) and Ryan Rickelton (81) to comfortably beat Kolkata Knight Riders by six wickets thus breaking the hoodoo of not winning any of their opening games in last 13 editions of the IPL on Sunday.

While they had lost each of their first matches of an IPL edition since beating Chennai Super Kings by eight wickets in 2012, five-time winners Mumbai Indians hit full throttle in their chase of 221, replying with 224/4 in 19.1 overs.

Playing his first T20 game since last IPL, former India and

Mumbai Indians captain Rohit appeared to have sharpened his game a few notches as he smacked a 38-ball 78 with six sixes and as many fours.

At the other end, Ryan Rickelton made a belligerent 81 off 43 balls with eight sixes and four fours while making the most of two lifelines, helping Mumbai Indians finally collect those elusive two points from the first game. Rohit was adroit in not just picking the lengths of the ball early or with his movement at the crease, but with some of the shots that he executed to perfection.

Like against the lanky Blessing Muzarabani, the 38-year-old danced down the track to spank a short ball over



Mumbai Indians' Rohit Sharma, right, and Ryan Rickelton run between the wickets during an Indian Premier League 2026 T20 cricket match between Mumbai Indians and Kolkata Knight Riders, at the Wankhede Stadium PTI

extra cover for a six in the fourth over, or when he timed the ball as sweetly as it could be against Varun Chakravorthy to send it sailing over the cover for another six in the next.

And those quintessential Rohit's hits over cover were on display too, one of which was unleashed effortlessly against Kartik Tyagi in the sixth as Rohit completed his half-century off a mere 23 balls. At the other end, Rickelton blissfully took down KKR's mystery spin duo of Sunil Narine and Chakravathy, targetting the leg-side boundaries to clear the ropes.

Rohit and Rickelton put on 148 off 72 balls to put MI in the driver's seat before falling to

Anukul Roy's brilliance in the outfield. It was the fifth-wicket pair of Hardik Pandya (18 not out) and Naman Dhir (5 not out) that took MI over the line. Earlier, skipper Ajinkya Rahane (67) and Angkrish Raghuvanshi (51) struck vital half-centuries but Kolkata Knight Riders posted a par score of 220 for 4.

On a placid wicket, Shardul Thakur (3/39) provided Mumbai crucial breakthroughs as their bowlers could not really impose themselves in their maiden outing. Both senior pacers Trent Boult (0/38) and Jasprit Bumrah (0/35) went wicketless but India pace spearhead's 18th and 20th over stopped KKR from getting closer to 250.

Rahane began with a wristy flick over wide long-on with exquisite timing for a six off Boult in the first over, KKR got the impetus when Pandya (1/39) erred throughout the fourth over to give away 26 runs. The skipper helped himself with two pick-up shots down the leg for consecutive sixes while Finn Allen (37 off 17 balls) drilled Pandya down the ground for a powerful hit for four, ending with a scoop past the 'keeper and short fine leg for a third boundary.

Before that, Allen had clobbered two sixes and a four off debutant Allah Ghazanfar (0/51) to collect 17 runs in the third over.

Despite Thakur striking on his second ball to get rid of

Finn, caught by Tilak Varma off an innocuous at long-on, KKR stood a happier side at 78/1 after the powerplay.

KKR crossed the 100-run mark inside the eighth over and Rahane looked set for a triple digit score at one stage, striking over 200.

But Thakur's twin strikes in separate spells broke the momentum for the visitors, which also saw the new batters not being able to keep up.

The burly Cameron Green was forced to chase short and wide deliveries by Thakur in the ninth over and on second such ball, the Australian hit it straight to Sherfane Rutherford who took a fine diving catch in front.



Breaks ensured I stay fresh and excited: Kohli

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The iconic Virat Kohli believes stepping away from the game at regular intervals has helped him stay mentally fresh and avoid burnout as he started the 2026 season by carving out his 28th IPL half-century.

Kohli's 38-ball 69, studded with five sixes and as many fours, powered Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a comfortable six-wicket win over Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL season opener on Saturday.

Playing his first T20 since last season's IPL final, Kohli showed little sign of rust, underlining how stepping away at regular intervals has helped him sustain peak performance despite a packed international schedule over the years.

Addressing concerns about being underprepared after a 10-month gap from the format, Kohli said the bigger challenge for him had always been avoiding burnout.

"Well, you know, the kind

of scheduling that we've had over the last 15 years and the amount of cricket I've played, for me there was always a risk of getting burnt out rather than being under-cooked. So these breaks helped me immensely. I stay fresh, I stay excited."

The 37-year-old stressed that he never returns to competitive cricket unless he is more than 100 percent.

"Whenever I come back to play, it's 120%. I'm not coming back, you know, underprepared. In fact, the extra rest helps me to mentally freshen up."

For Kohli, it is important to perform and not just hold onto a place.

"As long as you're physically fit and you're excited mentally, all those things come together nicely and then you're able to, you know, contribute for the team's cause and that's what you want to do as a player. You don't want to hold on to a spot.

"You want to keep performing and, you know, keep putting in the work for the team," he added.

Kohli’s energy bizarre at this age: Ravichandran Ashwin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

All praise for Virat Kohli, former off-spinner Ravichandran Ashwin says the Indian stalwart continues to "walk the talk" with his unmatched energy and intensity despite having retired from Test and T20 formats.

Returning to T20 cricket for the first time since last year's IPL final on June 3, Kohli showed no signs of rust, smashing his 28th IPL half-century (69 not out off 38 balls) to power defending champions Royal Challengers (RCB) Bengaluru to a commanding six-wicket win over Sunrisers Hyderabad in the 2026 season-opener.

"He walks the talk,"

Ashwin said on a JioHotstar show.

"It's almost like he's putting on a show for people to see how the game should be played, play it hard and play it the way it's meant to be played. That stood out for me with respect to what Virat did." Kohli was already in sublime touch coming into the IPL, having scored 93, 23 and 124 in the ODI series against New Zealand in January, where he finished as India's leading run-getter.

The 37-year-old had also topped the charts in the preceding series against South Africa in December, amassing 302 runs, including two centuries.

Ashwin further cited example of his running between the wickets to show



how his energy remains extraordinary despite his age and experience.

"I find him quite bizarre at this age. I tell him this during our chats now and then. He was batting on 40-odd, there

was a partnership going on, and RCB were coasting.

"He ran through for the first single, stopped there, and the other batter hadn't even reached halfway, but he was already looking for a

Samson, Jadeja face former teams as CSK meet RR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Sanju Samson is set for an emotional clash against Rajasthan Royals (RR), the side he led and shaped for over a decade, as he turns out for Chennai Super Kings (CSK), while Ravindra Jadeja will also face his former franchise, adding a poignant subplot to the IPL match between the two teams here on Monday.

For more than a decade, Samson was synonymous with RR, their batting mainstay, leader and all-time leading run-scorer who guided them to the 2022 final.

Much like MS Dhoni at CSK, Samson was the Royals' identity, but in a blockbuster



swap that sent Jadeja back to RR, the Kerala batter now finds himself in yellow, adding a new dimension to CSK's evolving core.

Samson also arrives in prime form, having played a decisive role in India's triumphant T20 World Cup campaign.

His hat-trick of 50-plus scores in must-win games

against West Indies, England and New Zealand has made him the star of the nation as the unassuming keeper-batter will come with a renewed self-belief.

He along with skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad, who are set to open also, will also form the core leadership of the team who will miss Dhoni for at least two weeks

due to a calf strain.

Dhoni has not travelled with the side to Guwahati as his absence will put Samson and Gaikwad in the spotlight. Dhoni's absence will also open the door for emerging names like 20-year-old left-arm spin all-rounder Prashant Veer who impressed in domestic T20s and the franchise's big-money (Rs 14.2-core) uncapped recruit Kartik Sharma, known for his six-hitting exploits in the domestic circuit.

With Dewald Brevis showing signs of maturity, Shivam Dube growing into a dependable middle-order force, and youngster Ayush Mhatre developing rapidly, CSK appear better equipped for a rebuild.

Padikkal finds white ball ruthlessness to power RCB’s early charge

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Devdutt Padikkal regally whipped pacer Jaydev Unadkat's full ball on his pads over backward square leg for a six.

It was not an unusual sight for a batter for whom flick forms one of the bread and butter shots.

But it was unprecedented because Devdutt has seldom hit a six off the first ball. The left-hander tends to settle down before unleashing himself on the bowlers.

However, the left-hander shed his linear nature against Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL 2026 opener here on Saturday, and it was just the beginning.

In the next 10 balls he faced, Devdutt produced two

more sixes and three fours, racing to 34 in 11 balls, strike-rate hovering over 300.

In fact, his 26-ball 61 was representative of the transformation happening to his batting since 2024 or early 2025.

In this period, Devdutt has made 543 runs at an average of 60.33 in the Ranji Trophy, 725 runs at 90.62 in the Vijay Hazare Trophy and 309 runs at a strike rate of 167.02 in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy.

Karnataka coach Yere Goud was not one bit surprised by his ward's outing against SRH.

"I think that boils down to his preparation. He is very clear about it. He goes about it keeping in mind the probability phase of plays - it changes according to where



he is batting from — power-play, mid-overs or the rest. I think that's contributing to his consistency," Goud told PTI.

Goud also felt that leading Karnataka has given Devdutt a lot more confidence as an individual and batter.

"See, he would have done

all these, I think, without captaincy also. But leading a side has its benefits, as he talks and learns from others in the team.

"There is that extra responsibility on the captain, and I think it has added some strong edges to his game now," said Goud.

Devdutt's own words reflected Goud's version.

"(RCB) Head Coach Andy Flower and Batting Coach Dinesh Karthik bhai really worked hard on me. It wasn't easy because there was a lot I needed to change. It wasn't just technical; it was a lot mentally as well. I needed to really believe that I can play this aggressive brand of cricket," Devdutt told Star Sports. That change was evident in his batting at the

Chinnaswamy.

Left-arm pacer David Payne tested Devdutt with a slower ball, but he judged it early and danced down the pitch to dismiss it over the mid-wicket for a six.

Pacer Eshan Malinga dug one a bit short, closer to the 25-year-old's body but he responded with a rasping cut past the point fielder for a boundary.

Left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey tried to pitch the ball away from his hitting arc, going wide on off-stump but the Karnataka batter drag-swept the ball to square leg for a four.

Devdutt retained his innate languidness in all these shots but there was a clear touch of ruthlessness and purpose in shot-making. (PTI)



One of our poorer bowling performances: SRH coach Vettori

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Sunrisers Hyderabad head coach Daniel Vettori labelled his side's bowling display against Royal Challengers Bengaluru as "poor", conceding they allowed Devdutt Padikkal and Virat Kohli far too many scoring opportunities in the IPL opener here.

After raising 201 for 9 in the season-opener on Saturday, the Hyderabad side could not tackle the marauding Padikkal and Kohli, watching RCB romp home in just 15.4 overs.

"You have to get a good start (with the ball), which we did against (Phil) Salt, but then I just think we weren't at our best with the ball. We weren't as disciplined as we needed to be, and we gave a lot of scoring opportunities to Virat and Padikkal, who played exceptionally well," Vettori said in the post-match press conference.

"We should have been able to maintain a little bit more (discipline) after getting that important wicket of Salt. So, it was a very good batting performance by RCB and one of our poorer bowling performances," he added.

Vettori said SRH had observed how well RCB pacer Jacob Duffy bowled but the visiting bowlers could not implement their plans effectively.

"I think we learned a lot from how RCB bowled and what was effective and what wasn't, but we just weren't able to implement that. You don't want to have a rusty performance because of how important every game is in the IPL, particularly how to start.

"But today was one of our challenging bowling displays. We saw at the back end when we started to go back to our usual disciplines that we could actually be effective and take some wickets. But I think we just missed our lengths too much. Duffy in particular showed the length to bowl on that surface," he said. Vettori hoped that young bowlers such as left-arm pacer David Payne and left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey will come good in coming matches.

The Hyderabad side managed to cross 200, but on a flat Chinnaswamy surface the total was vastly inadequate, and Vettori admitted as much. (PTI)

PM Modi lauds sporting achievements by Indian athletes, Jammu and Kashmir team

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday lauded sporting achievements by Indian athletes including Gulveer Singh, Anahat Singh and maiden Ranji Trophy victory by Jammu and Kashmir.

In his monthly 'Mann Ki Baat' address, Modi said Gulveer Singh, a talented athlete from Uttar Pradesh, has done wonders in one such sport, and just a few

weeks ago, he created history by finishing third in the New York City Half Marathon, he said. Singh became the first Indian athlete to complete a half-marathon in under an hour.

Modi also mentioned squash player "daughter Anahat Singh", who won a major international title in the Squash on Fire Open.

She achieved this success at just 17 years of age, becoming the youngest Asian female player to make it to

the top-20 in the Professional Squash Association (PSA) World Ranking, he added.

The prime minister said, "I also came to know about the Asmita Athletics League. In this, many sporting events were organised on the occasion of Women's Day on the 8th of March. Around 2 lakh daughters participated in the league."

"It is good to see that the women of India are playing an important role in this sporting transformation



taking place in the country," he said. He lauded the cricket team of Jammu and Kashmir for bagging the Ranji Trophy title for the first time and expressed hope that this winning streak of sports persons there continues in the future.

Modi said March has been a month full of excitement and enthusiasm for cricket fans across the country. He said when India achieved a historic victory in the T20 World Cup, a wave of joy

swept across the country and all citizens are very proud of the team's thumping success.

Late last month, a thrilling match was witnessed in Karnataka's Hubli, where the Jammu and Kashmir cricket team secured the Ranji Trophy, he said.

"It is most heartening to note that after a long wait of nearly seven decades, the team achieved its first Ranji Trophy title. This unprecedented success is the result of years of continuous efforts by

the players," he added.

Modi said the Jammu and Kashmir team captain, Paras Dogra, displayed extraordinary skills, and through his leadership he played a significant role in this victory.

He said the performance of young Kashmiri bowler Aaqib Nabi, who took 60 wickets in the Ranji Trophy, is being talked about nationwide. "This victory has thrilled the players and coaching staff, as well as the people of Jammu and Kashmir," he said.